

Atomic Diplomacy: Hiroshima and Potsdam

THE USE OF THE ATOMIC BOMB AND
THE AMERICAN CONFRONTATION
WITH SOVIET POWER

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American Diplomacy Takes the Offensive

Byrnes had already told me . . . that in his belief the bomb might well put us in a position to dictate our own terms at the end of the war.

—PRESIDENT HARRY S. TRUMAN on a conversation with James F. Byrnes in April 1945

THERE IS NO WAY to recapture the shock of the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. It requires an extraordinary feat of historical imagination to recreate the surprise and drama and horror of the day the world first learned of the atomic bomb. And it is all but impossible to recall the instant change in American thinking, the new sense of confidence and power the first atomic explosions engendered. To understand the impact of the new weapon upon diplomacy, one must go beyond the simple assertion that the added military power could be useful in war and in diplomatic maneuvering. In the first instance, its influence was psychological.

Truman's exuberance and Churchill's excitement at Potsdam show some of the emotional force of the new development. Though he had expected the bomb to be a success for many months, and despite the fact that at Potsdam he learned how greatly the test had exceeded expectations, when the President was informed of the successful bombing of Hiroshima, the effect was remarkable. Aboard the cruiser *Augusta*, Truman hurried back and forth telling officers and crew alike the news.¹ "I was greatly moved," the President has told us; and his sentiment was not remorse, but satisfaction. His first remark to

those with him at the time was the unqualified assertion, "This is the greatest thing in history!"²

To the average American, as well as to most senior government officials, news of the atomic bomb came first from the newspapers. Here too the weapon's power was disclosed in a way which produced great emotion and optimism about its usefulness as an instrument of high policy. On August 7, newspapers were filled with banner headlines announcing the devastation of Hiroshima.³ Not only was the development an unprecedented and amazing—indeed, at the time, fantastic—scientific feat, but at once the bomb's seemingly incredible power for war and peace was dramatically disclosed. In less time than it took to read a newspaper, the American public learned that the bomb might reduce the Japanese war from a publicly estimated year and a half to a few short weeks or even days. Immediately, news of Nagasaki convinced those who might have doubted the extent of the new power. In less than a week, the war—which until then had been a long series of costly island-to-island battles against an enemy who fought to the death—was suddenly over. Not only was the atomic bomb spectacular in itself, but it immediately demonstrated its apparent capacity to force surrender upon a powerful enemy.⁴

While the public at large was treated to the dramatic news of the weapon, the President and his senior advisers worked feverishly to end the Japanese war quickly. Ironically, the atomic bomb had not fulfilled one hope of the strategy of delay; with the Soong negotiations still stalled, on August 8—three months, to the day, after German capitulation—the Soviet Union declared war on Japan, and early the

² The *New York Herald Tribune* (Aug. 7, 1945) commented that the new force was "weird, incredible and somehow disturbing; one forgets the effect on Japan or on the course of the war as one senses the foundations of one's own universe trembling . . ."

³ In recalling the effect of the bombing upon the American public I wish only to point out that most Americans did not doubt (and do not doubt) that the atomic bomb ended the war. (See, for example, Truman, *Year of Decisions*, p. 426; Byrnes, *Speaking Frankly*, p. 264; *All in One Lifetime*, p. 308.) Though a good case can probably be made that the Soviet declaration of war actually provided the *coup de grâce*, there is no need to argue the point,

nor can a final answer to this question ever be given. However, note that the Japanese Cabinet did not decide to surrender after the first atomic bomb, that the Cabinet fixed its hopes on the undetermined Soviet attitude until the very moment Stalin declared war, that the Russian entry hit where it counted (ending the hope of the military leaders), and that American propaganda directed at Japan after Hiroshima stressed the importance of the Russian attack. (Ehrman, *Grand Strategy*, pp. 283, 306-7; Hewlett and Anderson, *The New World*, p. 403; Craven and Cate, *Air Forces in World War II*, Vol. V, pp. 730-32; S. E. Morison, "Why Japan Surrendered," *The Atlantic*, October 1960, p. 47.)

next morning the Red Army crossed the Manchurian border.⁵ In the few days between the Soviet declaration and the formal surrender of Japan, Stimson, Byrnes, and Truman continued to follow the basic line of strategy they had adopted during the summer. Stimson urged the President that "the thing to do was to get this surrender through as quickly as we can before Russia . . . should get down in reach of the Japanese homeland . . . It was of great importance to get the homeland into our hands before the Russians could put in any substantial claim to occupy and help rule it."⁶

Byrnes, of course, emphatically agreed.⁷ But an August 10 Japanese message accepting the Potsdam Proclamation was conditional; it asked guarantees that the Emperor's position be respected.⁸ Stimson urged that American assurances for the Emperor would produce a quick surrender.⁹ Byrnes, agreeing with the objective, disagreed on tactics—such assurances might appear as a sign of weakness and could "cause much delay."¹⁰ Finally, Truman accepted a suggestion by Forrestal that a message which implicitly recognized the Emperor's position but which was explicitly "unconditional" would be the best way to secure a prompt response.¹¹ In the meantime, "the President observed that we would keep up the war at its present intensity."¹²

Byrnes now attempted to arrange quick approval for this approach from the other Allies.¹² When Molotov asked for a day to consider the

American message, Byrnes made it clear through Harriman that the United States was quite prepared to accept the surrender without the Soviet Union unless approval for the American message was immediately given.¹³ Stalin quickly yielded to the American demand,¹⁴ and the message was sent to the Japanese on August 11.¹⁵ Now there was nothing to do except wait for the response.

Aware that each hour meant a further advance of the Soviet armies, and also some loss of life, American leaders now became extremely impatient.¹⁶ "Never have I known time to pass so slowly!" Byrnes recalls.¹⁷ When Japanese acceptance of the American message arrived, Byrnes abandoned all diplomatic requirements. Although the three powers had attempted to coordinate the acceptance and announcement of the German surrender,¹⁸ Byrnes now cut consultations short and, giving the other Allies less than three hours' notice, he declared that the President would announce acceptance of the Japanese surrender at 7 P.M., August 14; the others could join in at that time if they wished.¹⁹

Thus, the war was ended five days after the Red Army entered Manchuria. Despite the fact that the atomic bomb did not prevent the attack, however, it did fulfill the other hope of the strategy of delay. Truman has characterized the result: "Our dropping of the atomic bomb on Japan . . . forced Russia to reconsider her position in the Far East."²⁰ Indeed, as Stimson had predicted, after the bombing the relative positions of the United States and the Soviet Union were radically altered. A new firmness immediately appeared in American diplomacy and, correspondingly a new willingness to yield appeared in the Soviet stance.

After the New Mexico test, Truman had decided to exclude the Soviet Union from a significant role in the occupation and control of Japan.²¹ For this reason the August 11 message, as Stimson noted, "asserted that the action of the Emperor must be dominated by the Allied commander, using the singular to exclude any condominium."²² When Harriman had demanded immediate Soviet agreement to the message, Molotov had asked for time to consider just this point.²³ But Moscow was in no position to dispute American prerogatives and by endorsing the American message the Soviet government formally paved the way for unilateral American control of Japan.²⁴

* The tremendous desire to end the war quickly was expressed in many ways. Since the bomb dropped on Hiroshima accomplished the shock effect, the use of the second bomb against Nagasaki may well be explained by noting that Truman and Byrnes wished to leave absolutely no doubt about their resources or their intentions, and were anxious to avoid any time-consuming delays. Byrnes has testified they knew "the Japanese were patently anxious to surrender," but after the first Japanese acceptance message came in, Truman ordered conventional military operations to continue full force. At the Cabinet meeting on August 10, Stimson "suggested . . . that it would be a humane thing . . . that might affect the settlement if we stopped the bombing. . . ." However, his view was "rejected on the ground that it couldn't be done at once because we had not yet received in official form the Japanese surrender. . . ." Stimson's diary entry continues: "This of course was a correct but narrow reason, for the Japanese had broadcast their offer of surrender through every country in the world." (Stim-

son Diary, Aug. 10, 1945.) Forrestal's diary shows that Stimson also "cited the growing feeling of apprehension and misgiving as to the effect of the atomic bomb even in our own country," and that the Secretary of the Navy supported the advice that conventional bombing should cease. (Forrestal, *Diaries*, p. 83.) Truman refused to let up the pace even after the Japanese accepted the final American message, which implicitly acknowledged the position of the Emperor. Long after Radio Tokyo had broadcast acceptance of these terms (on August 14), but before the message had reached Washington through official channels, General Arnold (who wished to stage as big a finale as possible) was permitted to send 1,014 aircraft (approximately 800 B-29's and 200 fighters) to drop six thousand tons of conventional explosives on Honshu. (Byrnes, *All in One Lifetime*, p. 305; Truman, *Year of Decisions*, p. 423; Leahy, *I Was There*, pp. 434-36; Craven and Cate, *Air Forces in World War II*, Vol. V, pp. 699, 732-33; *New York Times*, Aug. 15, 1945.)

Similarly, Stalin could do very little when Truman simply refused his request that the Red Army be allowed to take a token surrender in the Japanese homeland (on the northern half of the island of Hokkaido).²⁵ And Stalin's readiness to accept American conditions after Hiroshima was underscored a week after surrender when an American proposal for a Far Eastern Advisory Commission was accepted.²⁶ This body, unlike the Control Commissions governing the other enemy states, was to be virtually powerless. Its location—in Washington—stressed the fact that it would have little control over the operating decisions of the Supreme Commander, General Douglas MacArthur, in Tokyo.²⁷ Thus, it was with the general approval of the Russians that Truman told the press on August 16 that Japan would not be divided into occupation zones, and declared in the first week of September that as far as Japan was concerned, "in the event of any differences of opinion [among the Allied powers] the policies of the United States will govern."²⁸

That the atomic bomb had strengthened the American hand was even more clearly demonstrated when the "tangled weave" of Manchurian issues was taken up. Japan, of course, was beyond the reach of the landlocked Red Army. But even in the area of Soviet military operations, Truman now found Stalin prepared to accept most American terms. The President had delayed the Manchurian negotiations all summer, and he had rejected the State Department's suggestion that they be concluded at Potsdam. However, as soon as the news of Hiroshima was made public, on August 7, 9, and 10, following his instructions, Harriman told Stalin and Soong that the United States believed the Chinese should make no further concessions.²⁹ With only a short debate, Stalin now conceded almost all of the points he had pressed so diligently during the past month of talks with Soong:† Dairen was to become a free port under Chinese administration

* Later, during the London Conference, Stalin reversed his attitude, demanding a greater role in Japan. As Walter Lippmann, James Reston, the *London Times*, the *Christian Science Monitor*, and others noted at the time, his reversal was probably in retaliation to the pressure Byrnes put on the

Soviet position in the Balkans. (*New York Herald Tribune*, Sept. 25; *New York Times*, Oct. 14; *London Times*, Oct. 2; *Christian Science Monitor*, Oct. 3, 1945.)

† See above, pp. 122–125.

(except in time of war),³⁰ and the jointly owned Manchurian railways were to be governed by a ten-man board of directors (five from each country) whose President was to be a Chinese Nationalist with decisive power to cast two votes.³¹ A treaty was initialed on August 14 which "generally satisfied" Chiang Kai-shek,³² and Ambassador Harriman cabled that T. V. Soong "was very grateful for our support and is convinced that unless we had taken an active part in the negotiations he would have had to accede to all Stalin's demands."³³

In Chungking, Ambassador Hurley was enthusiastic about the value of the treaties to internal Chinese politics. As in 1927, the Russians took a stand against the Chinese Communists:† "The publication . . . has demonstrated conclusively that the Soviet Government supports the National Government of China and also that the two governments are in agreement regarding Manchuria."³⁴ In America, most commentators expressed great satisfaction with the settlement in an area not administered by China for many years and under the direct military control of the Soviet Union.³⁵ On August 29, Madame Chiang visited Truman to thank him for his support. The President told his press conference: "She was very happy over the Russian-Chinese treaty, just as all of us are."³⁶

To be sure, at a later date the hopes these successful negotiations produced were to be dissipated. But at the time—and for a very considerable period—Stalin respected the treaties.³⁷ Chiang Kai-shek's administrators were permitted to take over civilian control in the Red Army zone of operations³⁸ and the American Air Force and Navy ferried thousands of Nationalist troops (who had no independent way to reach the area)³⁹ to Manchuria to take over responsibilities from the Russians.⁴⁰ Although Stalin took advantage of his position to remove a number of Manchurian industries as "war booty,"†⁴¹ the Red Army withdrew in April 1946.⁴² As the State Department later summarized the situation: "It was considered that Russia had accepted

* For the texts of the agreements, see Department of State, *Relations with China*, Annexes 51–59, pp. 585–96.

† And in 1959–1965?

‡ As I have noted, in the late autumn of 1945 a new Soviet *démarche* in the Far East seemed to be a direct response to the

American effort in the Balkans. (See above, p. 192/n.) It may well be that the Soviet interest in industrial reparations and "war booty" from Manchuria was also a response to the West's reluctance to adhere to the Yalta reparations formula and the subsequent breakdown of German administrative arrangements.

definite limitations on its activities in China and was committed to withhold all aid from the Chinese Communists. . . ."⁴³

Thus the primary American objectives in the Far East were achieved. Moreover, as had been expected throughout the summer, now Truman and Byrnes began to take the initiative to secure further political and commercial concessions in Manchuria. At Stimson's suggestion, Truman had also deferred an approach to the Russians on these additional matters during the summer.[†] At Potsdam he had rejected the suggestion that negotiations begin while Stalin and he were together. However, now the "appropriate time"[‡] had arrived. In his first approach to Molotov after Hiroshima, Harriman was instructed to attempt to secure a new public statement affirming Soviet support for America's traditional "Open Door" policy in the area.⁴⁴ Molotov initially responded that such a statement was superfluous, since Stalin had repeatedly confirmed his support for this policy.⁴⁵ But Truman and Byrnes persisted, on August 22 instructing Harriman to press the matter with Stalin himself.⁴⁶ This effort succeeded. On August 27 the Soviet Premier overruled his foreign minister and said he was prepared to issue the declaration sought by Washington.⁴⁷

THE SECRET CLOSE-IN APPROACH

IN THE WHIRLWIND DAYS immediately after Hiroshima and Nagasaki, American diplomacy changed so swiftly that few observers have caught the sweep of all the policy decisions unveiled in a few short weeks. Secretary Byrnes, however, has emphasized the importance of this brief period. Underscoring the breadth and scope of new diplomatic departures, he has recalled: "Those . . . days . . . were full of action."⁴⁸ In fact, the sheer volume of work caused the Secretary of

* Although it is still a matter of dispute to what extent Stalin aided the Chinese Communists in the first postwar years, there is substantial agreement that his assistance, if of any importance at all, was extremely limited. (Beloff, *Soviet Policy*, pp. 42-43; Department of State, *Relations with China*, p. 121.) The Red Army withdrew from Manchuria in April 1946. (*Ibid.*, p. 147; McNeill, *America, Britain and Russia, 1941-46*, p. 709.) As late as June 1947, Byrnes made no complaints that Stalin was supporting the Chinese Communists. At that time

Byrnes was still able to write: "Whether Stalin will continue to resist the temptation . . . is a question which . . . remains in the balance." (Byrnes, *Speaking Frankly*, pp. 227-29, 293.) Similarly, as late as September 1947 the Chinese Foreign Minister wished to do nothing which might cause Stalin to reconsider his obligations under the Sino-Soviet treaty. (Department of State, *Relations with China*, p. 121.)

† See above, pp. 98, 101-103.

‡ See above, p. 124.

State to ask that the London foreign ministers' meeting set for September 1 be postponed until September 10.⁴⁹

Amongst all the activities, however, unquestionably the most important concerned atomic energy. At precisely the same time American Far Eastern diplomacy was achieving its objectives, Truman and Byrnes also made it clear that the United States intended to maintain its atomic monopoly.

Truman's August 6 statement—released with the news of Hiroshima—revealed that "it is not intended to divulge the technical processes of production or all the military applications."⁵⁰ In his August 9 report to the nation, the President declared: "The atomic bomb is too dangerous to be loose in a lawless world . . . We must constitute ourselves trustees of this new force."⁵¹ Within a week of the presidential statement, the War Department released a long report on atomic energy with the notice: "The best interests of the United States require the utmost cooperation by all concerned in keeping secret now and for all time in the future all scientific and technical information. . . ."⁵² In another week Truman directed that no information on the nuclear development project be released without the specific approval of the President.^{*53}

Thus, Truman made public his resolve to maintain the production secrets of the new weapon. His declarations revealed that Stimson's early idea of exchanging information on nuclear energy (and simultaneously establishing international controls) had been rejected. Instead of the theory that the new development might be used as a bargaining counter with which to obtain diplomatic *quid pro quos* from the Russians, there was to be what Stimson had once described as "the secret close-in attempted control of the project by those who control it now."⁵⁴ Although initially Truman had had to decide only that diplomacy would be delayed until the atomic weapons were demonstrated, by the end of July he had also resolved the nascent dispute between Stimson and Byrnes; the President had adopted the Secretary of State's more narrow view that a temporary monopoly of nuclear weapons, in itself, would be valuable to diplomacy.[†]

* Churchill praised this decision in the House of Commons. (5th Series, *Hansard*, Vol. 413, Commons, 76-86.) Shortly thereafter Stimson's successor, Robert Patterson, reassured Congress that "the President has

already said that he would not reveal the atomic bomb itself at all . . ." (U.S. House of Representatives, *Hearings: Atomic Energy Act*, Oct. 9, 18, 1945, p. 66.)

† See above, pp. 62-64.

Indeed, although the policy decision was taken in late July and made public only on August 6, the crucial assumptions of the narrow view had been adopted as early as the first week of June; for, despite Stimson's hopeful discussion of diplomatic *quid pro quos*, the Interim Committee had been strongly influenced by the Secretary of State-designate. In the May 31 meeting of the Committee, the director of the Los Alamos laboratories, J. Robert Oppenheimer, had argued that under a system of controls the United States should offer the world free interchange of nuclear information, with special emphasis on peacetime uses. He had felt the nation would strengthen its moral position if it acted before using the bomb.⁵⁵ General Marshall and Assistant Secretary of State Clayton, however, had argued against putting faith in a system of inspection safeguards for international control.⁵⁶ General Marshall had added his opinion that it would be best to build up a combination of like-minded powers that would bring Russia into line by the very force of the coalition.⁵⁷ As the discussion progressed, Byrnes had intervened decisively; he argued against giving information to the Russians, even in general terms. He concluded that the best policy was to push production and research and make certain that the United States stayed ahead.⁵⁸

Byrnes's prestige—and his status as personal representative of the President—had not been ignored. The Interim Committee unanimously concurred in his judgment: It would be best to push research and production, to maintain secrecy, and to establish a combination of democratic powers for cooperation in atomic energy.⁵⁹ Byrnes and the Committee also expressed hope that some form of cooperation with Russia could be worked out so that under a control system each country would make public whatever work was being done on the subject.⁶⁰ However, in reality the Committee's recommendations all but excluded the possibility of international control of atomic energy: The Russians were unlikely to accept continued American production and research without attempting to secure nuclear weapons for themselves, and the Committee had no specific control proposals to make. Aware of the limitations of this approach, even as Stimson had discussed *quid pro quos* with the President on June 6, he had acknowledged that the Committee's ideas were "imperfect" and that they "might not be assented to by Russia." But he had told the President

that "we were far enough ahead of the game to be able to accumulate enough material to serve as insurance."⁶¹

Thus, in the end, even Stimson, who knew that a nuclear monopoly could not be maintained, and who was deeply concerned by the prospect of an arms race, had given priority to continued weapons production and research instead of an attempt to establish international controls. Stimson briefly took great interest in a proposal that further production of atomic weapons should be halted temporarily as evidence of good faith, so that an approach to Russia could be attempted, but he did not pursue the idea.⁶² On June 21 the Interim Committee, preparing a statement to be issued by the President, struck out a proposed sentence which would have committed the United States to attempt to achieve international control of atomic energy.⁶³ Stimson accepted the draft,⁶⁴ but although he continued to be troubled that, as he had once expressed it, "modern civilization might be completely destroyed,"⁶⁵ apparently few other members of the Interim Committee shared his fears.*

Most important, the President's personal representative, Secretary Byrnes, had few doubts about the wisdom of the "close-in" approach.⁶⁶ He believed the temporary atomic monopoly would be a great advantage to American diplomacy.⁶⁷ In his view, the primary task was to establish a "lasting structure of peace."⁶⁸ A stable Europe, essential to world peace and American security alike, was the number-one goal.⁶⁹ Byrnes also believed that the nuclear monopoly could be maintained for at least seven years.⁷⁰ He appears to have been convinced that within this period, with the support of the revolutionary new weapon, his diplomacy could easily achieve its idealistic objectives. Thus, the weapon seemed a crucial factor in forcing agreement to an American plan for permanent peace—a plan which, *ipso facto*, would prevent another world war. Since this vision promised an end to all war it implicitly obviated the danger of an arms race. There seemed plenty of time to accomplish the task before the Russians might break the American monopoly.† In any case, as Byrnes has written, "no one

* Oppenheimer is an exception. See Atomic Energy Commission, *Oppenheimer Hearings* for repeated references to his personal depression during this period and his fear for the future.

† "Permanent peace," or "lasting peace," or "durable peace," seems to have been a universal objective of American policy makers. (See above, pp. 53, 78.) In retro-
(Continued on next page)

seemed too alarmed at the prospect, because it appeared that in seven years we should be far ahead of the Soviets in this field."⁷¹

Byrnes's arguments for secrecy and continued production of weapons convinced not only the Interim Committee but also the President. Although during June Truman also spoke optimistically of diplomatic *quid pro quos*, he accepted the recommendations presented to him. In mid-July, at Potsdam, the President told Churchill he would "at all costs . . . refuse to divulge any particulars."⁷² He later wrote: "I had decided that the secret of the manufacture of the weapon would remain a secret with us."⁷³

Indeed, during the Potsdam Conference both the President and Stimson lost the trace of interest in international controls each had evidenced earlier in the summer. Depressed by the omnipresent Soviet secret police in Berlin, both came to the conclusion that a control scheme could hope to succeed only if Russia were to become an open, democratic society.⁷⁴ As Harriman pointed out (and as Stimson soon realized),⁷⁵ to attempt to force the Soviet Union to change its national system would be to demand something no great power could consider.⁷⁶ However, once accepted, the idea that controls could be established only if Russia became a democracy inevitably destroyed even the meager remaining hope of international cooperation. Stimson's diary shows that this realization "troubled me a great deal,"⁷⁷ but as Truman has testified, the Secretary of War no longer urged the exchange of important information on the weapon.⁷⁸ And Stimson returned from Potsdam strongly opposed to the release of any atomic information.*⁷⁹

The President later (in September) expressed some interest in meth-

(Continued from preceding page)

spect it is not surprising that leading officials, having personally experienced two world wars in one lifetime, should have aimed so consistently for a proper basis—as they defined it—which would eliminate a third world war. Nor, indeed, is it surprising that once given the unexpected power of the atomic bomb that they should have regarded the weapon as a means to achieve their goal. In this early period, Byrnes's view was the most straightforward, but compare Churchill's statement to the House of Commons, August 16, 1945: "The United States stand at this moment at the summit of the world . . . Let them act up to the level of their power . . . So far as we know, there are at least three and per-

haps four years before the concrete progress made in the United States can be overtaken. In these three years we must remould the relationships of all men, wherever they dwell, in all the nations. . . ." (5th Series, *Hansard*, Vol. 413, Commons, 80.) The newly available information on Byrnes's view also illuminates a previously enigmatic statement in his memoirs. Recalling discussions of the bomb with Churchill at Potsdam, Byrnes states: "In addition to his tremendous interest in the effect of the bomb on the war with Japan [Churchill] foresaw more clearly than many others the possibilities presented by the release of atomic energy." (*Speaking Frankly*, p. 262.) For more information on Byrnes's view, see Hewlett and Anderson, *The New World*,

ods for "controlling bomb warfare"⁸⁰ but the idea of sharing important information under a control scheme was dropped—"As far as I was concerned, this was not a matter for discussion."⁸¹ Having accepted Byrnes's basic recommendations and having agreed that no control would be possible until the Soviet Union changed its system, Truman automatically—and apparently quite confidently—ended up strongly supporting the narrow view of his Secretary of State. Even before Potsdam there is little evidence that Truman showed much personal interest in promoting attempts to establish international controls. During the Conference he rejected the idea that frank relations and international cooperation required that he tell Stalin of the new weapon before using it.† After the Conference the President followed Byrnes's recommendations that no approach to the Russians be made. He told de Gaulle that because the United States had the only atomic bombs, "the peace problem . . . was therefore largely economic."⁸² Stimson's Potsdam advice, which made control seem impossible, had bolstered Byrnes's conception of the role of the bomb in diplomacy; Truman concluded that so long as no "foolproof" method of control existed, "it was important to retain the advantage which the possession of the bomb had given us."‡⁸³

pp. 354–60, 417, 418, 456, 458–59, 461, 469, 532; Atomic Energy Commission, *Openheimer Hearings*, p. 33; *The New York Times*, Sept. 6, 1945; Byrnes, *Speaking Frankly*, pp. 87, 179, 203, 261; *All in One Lifetime*, pp. 284, 303; Stimson Diary, Aug. 12–Sept. 3, Sept. 5, Sept. 11, 1945. The reader will note that I have not mentioned as one of the reasons for Byrnes's opposition to control schemes his belief that they were technically impossible. From all the evidence I have seen, it is quite clear that Byrnes began with the idea of basing his diplomacy on the atomic bomb (as his early April discussions with Truman show). Though he certainly distrusted the Russians, there is little evidence that at this time he opposed international control schemes because of doubts about their feasibility. Rather, he simply had no interest in any of the various schemes suggested which might have deprived him of the key factor in his diplomacy.

In 1947 Byrnes came to the conclusion that when the Russians caught up there would be little likelihood of war. Recalling that neither party used poison gas or germ warfare during the Second World War, he argued that a parallel situation would eventually be reached: "No nation dared use

these terrible weapons because they knew the same weapons would be used against them." (*Speaking Frankly*, p. 276.) Though Byrnes failed to achieve his diplomatic objectives, if the present delicate balance of terror can be maintained, ironically Byrnes's prediction may be borne out.

* Stimson later reconsidered his entire viewpoint. See Appendix III.

† See above, pp. 156, 183.

‡ The last sentence is Truman's 1955 recollection. From the evidence I have seen, however, it appears that between April and August 1945 Truman never had more than a passing interest in the idea of international control. Despite his comments about *quid pro quos*, in practice he seems to have consistently agreed with Byrnes that the implied threat of the weapon could not be given up to an international control scheme. Available evidence does not permit a final determination of how Truman saw the problem at the time, but as I have shown, even taking Truman's recollection at its face value, by the time of Potsdam he had defined the control problem in a way which could not be resolved. Thus, on his own terms the "advantage which the possession of the bomb had given us" could only be the advantage urged by Byrnes.

In this way the ideas Byrnes had urged during the summer became American policy: When it came, the much delayed showdown would not be based upon exchanging an international control system for diplomatic *quid pro quos*. Instead the "advantage" of the weapon could only be its value as an "implied threat."* The consolidation of this viewpoint was confirmed privately at the same time the President offered his public pledges to guard the secrecy of the new development. In early August, immediately after Hiroshima and Nagasaki, Assistant Secretary of War McCloy found Byrnes resolutely against any negotiations looking toward the international control of atomic energy.⁸⁴ The Secretary of State reiterated that "in his opinion we should continue the Manhattan Project with full force."⁸⁵ Similarly, Byrnes, representing the President, transmitted a direction through General Groves to J. Robert Oppenheimer that the work at Los Alamos was not to let up.⁸⁶ Expenditures of the Manhattan Project rose during the first months of peace from 43 million dollars in August to 51 million in September to 59 million in October.⁸⁷

Byrnes's dominant position in policy making was evidenced in other ways immediately after Potsdam. The scientific panel of the Interim Committee now reported that thermonuclear weapons might be developed, and that their power would greatly exceed the power of the fission weapons used in Japan. It was the panel's "unanimous and urgent recommendation" that such developments be controlled by international agreement. Again, however, the President's personal representative took a negative view of any attempt to approach the Russians. Oppenheimer, who had helped draft the report and had carried the panel's recommendation to Byrnes, was told that the "proposal about an international agreement was not practical and that he and the rest of the gang should pursue their work [on the hydrogen weapon] full force."⁸⁸

REMOVING THE SOVIET BLACKOUT FROM THE BALKANS

TRUMAN'S STATEMENT that the United States would act as "trustees" of the new force came in his August 9 report to the nation on

* The term is taken from Stimson's diary report of Byrnes's privately expressed view of the bomb. (See below, p. 255.) Within a month the Secretary of War came to oppose the Byrnes view. On September 11,

he also argued against "a succession of express or implied threats or near threats in our peace negotiations." (Stimson, *On Active Service*, p. 645.)

the Potsdam Conference. Thus, just as the atomic bomb had been intimately related to his European policy throughout the summer, the disclosure of the President's approach to the new weapon was implicitly linked to his first postwar discussion of European issues. Once again, however, it is necessary to recall that American departures in European diplomacy, in Far Eastern diplomacy, and in atomic-energy policy were revealed simultaneously, and in a great rush in the crowded second, third, and fourth weeks of August.

Truman's August 9 report on Potsdam emphasized his sense of confidence and optimism about the future; the Allies would "continue to march together to a lasting peace and a happy world."⁸⁹ Although he was not yet able to report that all his European objectives had been achieved, the President offered a convincing argument that the ultimate goal, a politically and economically stable Europe, would be achieved. In the main, the American proposals for Germany had been accepted. Agreement on political principles had been reached and, most important, the economic issue, which was dominated by the reparations question, had been settled along the lines of American proposals: The "idea of attempting to fix a dollar value . . . was dropped."⁹⁰ The President looked forward to early agreement on various other proposals when the foreign ministers held their first peacetime meeting in London. Soon most of the issues postponed at Potsdam might be settled.⁹¹

At the time Truman was making these remarks cooperative relations with the Russians began on a hopeful note almost everywhere on the Continent. In Germany, Eisenhower and Zhukov quickly established a warm friendship and close working relations.⁹² Plans for free interzonal politics and trade were laid (and soon implemented).⁹³ In Austria, General Mark Clark was less successful in his personal relationships, but he too found a considerable degree of Soviet coopera-

* The moderate Soviet approach in East Germany and elsewhere during the early autumn of 1945 has been noted by many observers; and the radical changes which took place later have yet to be adequately explained. In addition to the fact that free enterprise, free trade, free travel, and free politics were promoted by the Russians in East Germany during this period, in October the Red Army ripped up vital rail communications extending from the Soviet Union through Poland to Germany. For more information on this fascinating

but unexplored period, see Slusser, *Soviet Economic Policy in Postwar Germany*, pp. 16, 19, 20, 42, 55; Nettl, *The Eastern Zone and Soviet Policy in Germany, 1945-50*, pp. 80, 81, 281, 292; Leonhard, *Child of Revolution*, pp. 352, 379, 391, 411, 413-15, 427; Eisenhower, *Crusade in Europe*, p. 444. Similarly, at this time the Red Army, which controlled the greater part of Czechoslovakia and Hungary, withdrew. (McNeill, *America, Britain and Russia, 1941-46*, p. 734; Betts, *Central and South East Europe*, p. 126.)

tion immediately after Potsdam.⁹⁴ In Poland—the original symbol of Truman's policy—there also seemed to be signs of hope. At Potsdam, Truman had again secured Stalin's support for an early free election and for unrestricted reporting by Western correspondents.⁹⁵ Assistant Secretary of State Clayton and Ambassador Harriman had carried forward talks regarding economic aid with the Polish government.⁹⁶ Immediately after Potsdam, American correspondents requested permission to enter the country. (The Polish government agreed on August 24, and the reporters soon enjoyed unrestricted freedom.)⁹⁷ Ambassador Lane laid plans to bring to a culmination the summer strategy of attempting to bargain American credits for early elections and unrestricted trade. And, just as Truman had been confident the approach would work in April, Lane seemed to find every reason to believe the approach would now succeed.*

Thus, there seemed a reasonable basis for Truman's hopeful review of most European questions. But in his Potsdam report to the nation the President also discussed Southeastern Europe. And here, as had been clear before and during the Potsdam meeting, the Russians were not so amenable to American plans. Consequently, once again from Truman's point of view Southeastern Europe presented the most immediate challenge to American European policy. Truman's Potsdam demand that the governments of Bulgaria and Rumania be changed had been refused, but the President had made it quite clear that he was willing to postpone, not withdraw, his demand. Now, immediately after Hiroshima and Nagasaki, he publicly declared: "These nations are not to be spheres of influence of any one power."⁹⁸ ✱

This statement of American opposition to Soviet domination of the Balkans was of major political significance. Here was the first open and public break in the wartime alliance. And immediately the President and his Secretary of State demonstrated that the declaration meant what it said: The United States demanded that the governments subservient to Soviet influence be removed. From the American point of view, forcing agreement on this issue was important not only in

* Lane held his first explicit talks with the Poles on September 3. Hoping to secure early free elections and the elimination of discriminatory trading agreements, he carried forward the April strategy in discussions throughout the autumn. "With complete candor," he stated that economic aid would

be forthcoming only if the American proposals were accepted: "I determined to take advantage of the eagerness of the Polish Government for economic assistance and to use it as a lever. . . ." (Lane, *I Saw Poland Betrayed*, p. 145.)

itself, but also because the issue, like the Polish question in April, now came to symbolize American opposition to a Soviet sphere of influence throughout Eastern Europe. The crucial decision of the summer had been to delay a confrontation on this fundamental question until the atomic bomb had been demonstrated, and although the Potsdam meeting had unavoidably come a few weeks too soon, now there was no longer any reason to wait.

As early as mid-April, Byrnes had told the President that in his belief the bomb might well put America in a position to dictate terms at the end of the war.⁹⁹ He had told one of the nuclear scientists that the demonstration and possession of the new weapon would make Russia more manageable in Eastern Europe, specifically mentioning Poland, Rumania, and Hungary.* Now Secretary Byrnes set about the task of implementing his own basic view. In Byrnes's approach to the Balkans, and in Truman's support for this approach—more than in any other single diplomatic effort—American leaders demonstrated that the strategy of delay had reached its long-awaited climax. Together with British leaders, American policy makers now attempted to fulfill the President's summer pledge to "insist on the eventual removal of the Soviet blackout."¹⁰⁰

Truman's declaration of opposition to spheres of influence was what one observer termed "the first gun" in an "Anglo-American diplomatic offensive."¹⁰¹ In a series of powerful statements other American and British leaders drove home the President's point. Prime Minister Clement Attlee told Parliament he "looked forward with hope to the emergence of democratic governments based on free elections" in the Balkans.¹⁰² Foreign Minister Bevin, revealing the Potsdam change in the British approach, declared that he would refuse to recognize the governments of Hungary, Bulgaria, and Rumania until free elections were held.¹⁰³ He added that under Soviet control, in his opinion, "one kind of totalitarianism [was] being replaced by another."¹⁰⁴ Winston Churchill publicly introduced the term "the iron

* Before his death, Dr. Leo Szilard offered a few more details of his May 28 conversation with the Secretary of State-designate: "Byrnes was concerned about Russia's having taken over Poland, Rumania, and Hungary, and so was I. Byrnes thought

that the possession of the bomb by America would render the Russians more manageable in Europe. I failed to see how. . . ." (*U.S. News & World Report*, Aug. 15, 1960, p. 69.)

curtain"* and demanded an end to the "police governments," in the area.¹⁰⁵ At the same time he told the Commons his belief that the atomic bomb gave the West "irresistible" powers.¹⁰⁶

In these speeches the privately expressed confidence so apparent at Potsdam was publicly manifested. Churchill's speech in the Commons made no attempt to hide the relationship between the new weapon and his judgment that the West now had the power to force Soviet acceptance of their approach in the Balkans. Although American spokesmen were not so explicit in public, a number of commentators noted the direct relationship between the "entirely new sense of confidence" in diplomacy and the atomic explosions. Indeed, it was all but impossible to miss the connection, for Truman's disclosure of the confrontation in the Balkans was heralded by the commanding news of the two atomic bombings; and the destruction of Nagasaki and the President's attack upon spheres of influence were made public on precisely the same day, August 9.[†]

The Anglo-American assault upon Soviet predominance in the Balkans was made despite the Churchill-Stalin arrangement, the armistice agreements, and the Yalta decisions. In fact, Truman's public declaration was a unilateral act which contravened the assumptions of an understanding the President had signed only a week earlier.¹⁰⁷ At Potsdam, Truman had acknowledged the authority of the Allied Control Commissions in each country and had reaffirmed the

* It had been used in private cables earlier. (Churchill, *Triumph and Tragedy*, p. 573.) It is interesting to note that almost immediately after Churchill used the term in the Commons the original situation it was meant to describe changed. Churchill used the term specifically to mean that British officials were restricted in their movements in Poland and the Balkans ("an iron fence had come down around them"—*Conference of Berlin*, II, p. 362) and to mean that Western correspondents were not allowed free range. However, at Potsdam the Western representatives were given all the additional rights in the Soviet zone that they asked (*Conference of Berlin*, II, pp. 1494-95), and after Potsdam, Western correspondents were given free access to Poland, Rumania, and Bulgaria. (State Department *Bulletin*, Aug. 26, 1945, pp. 283-84; *New York Times*, Sept. 13, 1945.) Hungary, of course, never presented a major problem in this respect. Although Churchill introduced his term in the autumn of 1945, it was only

considerably later that a new "iron curtain" descended in the Soviet zone of Europe.

† C. L. Sulzberger, noting the "diplomatic offensive" in the Balkans, commented: "The disclosure of an effective atomic weapon, completely shifting the actual balance of military power . . . revised the entire over-all atmosphere and the realities of a situation in which two rival Allied pressures were operating against each other." (*New York Times*, Aug. 26, 1945.) James Reston also noted the new American confidence and related it to the atomic explosions, which disclosed "the actuality of preponderant military power." (*Ibid.*) The *New York Herald Tribune* (Aug. 29, 1945) commented on the widespread opinion "that it is the Truman firmness, backed by the atom bomb and the five-ocean navy, which has produced the very moderate Sino-Russian treaty, the about-face in Bulgaria, the non-interference . . . in the internal affairs of the new Polish state and similar manifestations."

principle of joint action through the Commissions. Indeed, he had emphasized his commitment by successfully urging that the status of American members of the Commissions be raised, and that they be given veto powers.¹⁰⁸ Now, simply bypassing the Commissions and the obligations of the armistice terms, Truman's statement made a unilateral appeal to public opinion in each country. And following the appeal, Secretary Byrnes began a campaign of direct intervention in the internal politics of Hungary, Bulgaria, and Rumania.

Hungary was the first problem, but the least difficult, for Churchill's understanding seemed to be operating fairly well. The Russians were working closely with a government headed by the conservative General Bela Miklos, a former supporter of the Horthy dictatorship.¹⁰⁹ The State Department believed "the present 'Provisional National Government' [to be] a coalition regime representing all important anti-Nazi parties."¹¹⁰ However, Byrnes urged better facilities for free campaigning and demanded that the already scheduled elections be postponed until new arrangements could be made.¹¹¹ Even before Potsdam, the Russians had shown themselves willing to admit the Allies to equal power on the Hungarian Allied Control Commission, and new procedures, permitting a Western veto, had actually been put into operation by July 16.¹¹² Now the Russians quickly acceded to the American demand, postponing the election on August 29.¹¹³ Budapest municipal elections were held on October 7. The Soviet pledge of free elections was strictly adhered to, and the Communist party suffered a resounding defeat. The Hungarian national election of November 4 produced a similar result.¹¹⁴

Thus, the Russians were apparently willing to yield to American demands in Hungary. In Bulgaria and Rumania, where Soviet interests were greater (80-20 and 90-10 respectively, in Churchill's calculations) Stalin had not yielded to Truman's main demands at Potsdam. Now, after Hiroshima, the President forced a test of the new power relationships. Bulgaria was first. Here domestic political conflicts had begun to take on international implications earlier in the year, but there had been little active maneuvering for position between the big powers and Soviet responsibility had not been directly challenged during the war. Nevertheless, it was already clear that

politicians within the country had begun to look to one or another of the powers to back their various causes.¹¹⁵

When the Fatherland Front government was formed it originally had the support of the Agrarian and Social Democratic parties.¹¹⁶ The most important political personality among these groups was Nikola Petkov, the Agrarian leader.¹¹⁷ However, the alliance which had brought together the Agrarian and Zveno parties on the one hand, with the Social Democratic and Communist parties on the other, was extremely unstable.¹¹⁸ During the winter of 1944–45 Petkov and his followers accused the Communists of attempting to use the joint Fatherland Front committees—which governed Bulgarian towns and cities—to increase their own political strength in the country.¹¹⁹ The Communists denied the accusation and charged the conservative groups with working against the occupying Soviet troops, a contravention of the armistice agreement,¹²⁰ and a breach of faith which would undermine the Fatherland Front government.¹²¹

The tension caused by the political crisis was severe; it divided groups not only along party lines, but within the parties as well. The basic cleavage appeared over the general question of to what extent it was necessary to cooperate with the Soviet Union and the Communists.¹²² The spokesman for those who believed cooperation essential was the Zveno party leader and prime minister, Kimon Georgiev. The American State Department representative, Maynard Barnes, found Georgiev “a true conservative in his views of the sacredness of private property (otherwise he could never have held highest political office in country) . . .”¹²³ However, the Prime Minister also felt it necessary to establish a working relationship with the Russians. On July 30, Barnes reported:

[Georgiev] sees world as largely divided between three great powers and their respective spheres of influence. It is his belief Balkans fall squarely within Russian sphere. He considers himself too much of a realist to [accept] the view that spheres of influence are outmoded. . . .¹²⁴

Georgiev and others believed cooperation with the Communists and the promotion of the Fatherland Front government the *sine qua non* of a viable Bulgarian political accommodation to the postwar power realities. However, others, like Petkov, disagreed. They dis-

trusted the Communists and hoped that if an immediate “free” election could be held, their power among the conservative peasant groups would thrust them into a dominant political position. They hoped that the Western powers would take their side against the Soviet occupation forces and enable them to establish a new government which would implement their more conservative political program.¹²⁵ Nevertheless, Petkov was not the spokesman for a united group of conservative politicians. Like the Prime Minister Georgiev, many other conservatives within the Agrarian and Social Democratic parties believed the Fatherland Front the only possible course for Bulgaria.

In fact, throughout 1945 differences of opinion over this issue engendered violent debate and hostility, splitting the Agrarian party into “cooperation” and “anticooperation” factions.¹²⁶ A test of strength took place between the groups at the May 1945 congress of the party. Petkov denounced the congress and the “cooperative” line it espoused.¹²⁷ However, the congress elected the right-wing Alexander Obbov leader of the Agrarian party on a platform of cooperation with the Fatherland Front.¹²⁸ This split the Agrarians into an official Obbov wing promoting cooperation and the dissident Petkov wing urging a more and more critical view.¹²⁹

Though still a member of the Cabinet, Petkov obviously needed all the political support he could find, for he faced the combined forces of the Russian occupation and the remainder of the Fatherland Front government. It was not surprising that he looked first to the American representative for help. In Maynard Barnes he found an extremely sympathetic ally. Almost from the first, Barnes took Petkov's side.¹³⁰ Because it also sympathized with Petkov's views, the State Department championed the opposition demand for immediate “free” elections.¹³¹ The Russians exercised their power under the armistice to reject an American bid for supervision of the elections in mid-April while the war still continued, but they promised early free elections on the Finnish pattern soon after the war's end.¹³² A few weeks after Germany collapsed, an election date—August 26—was set.¹³³

From May to July the political struggle within Bulgaria focused on preparations for the coming election. The past history of democracy in the country was not very promising.¹³⁴ The opposition quite naturally feared that the Fatherland Front would manage the election so as to preclude a free campaign and they were extremely suspicious of

the election plans.¹³⁵ Petkov and a small dissident faction of the Social Democratic party, with the support of Barnes, raised the Yalta pledge of free elections as their standard.¹³⁶ Together, Petkov's supporters and the American representative (who went to the limit—and perhaps beyond—of his instructions) urged that the election plans be liberalized.¹³⁷ Both the Agrarian leader and Barnes attempted to secure open American support for a vigorous campaign to promote three-power supervision—or at least observation—of the elections.

Barnes's strategy was to avoid any act which would increase the status of the Soviet-backed government. For this reason in June he vigorously opposed signing a peace treaty with the Georgiev government, and he disputed as "spurious" the British "contention that conclusion of peace with Bulgaria now would entail withdrawal of Soviet troops."¹³⁸ Instead, he argued that if a new government could be formed on the basis of a free election, American influence would be greatly increased: "In the event we raised the question with Russia of continued occupation of Bulgaria by its troops we could count not only upon having the mass of Bulgn people behind us, but also the Bulgn Govt."¹³⁹

Searching for a political handhold, Barnes seized upon the conservative peasant vote: "As I see matters so far as Bulgaria is concerned, the hope of the democratic nations must be based on the wide mass of agrarian opinion in this country . . ."¹⁴⁰ Hence, he recommended a determined effort to promote free democratic elections as a means to support "this overwhelming mass of the Bulgn population in the only way that is left to us."¹⁴¹ In sum, on the eve of Potsdam he argued: "There seems only one wise course, namely to do everything we can at present to assure the freest election possible with the widest democratic participation that pressure from U.S. at this time can effect."¹⁴²

Barnes met "clandestinely" (to use his term) with Petkov and his followers even before Potsdam and encouraged them in their opposition to the Fatherland Front.¹⁴³ Though prevented from making a direct pledge of American support, Barnes discussed the election situation with high Bulgarian government officials, indicating the likelihood that the Allies might soon intervene to postpone the scheduled elections, and urging more rigorous safeguards for the opposition.¹⁴⁴ At the same time, Barnes begged his own government for an all-out

effort to support Petkov and the other opposition politicians. Cabling home, he repeatedly reminded the State Department of its interpretation of the Yalta free election ideal:

If democratic elements within and outside the [Fatherland] Front could be made aware of views to which I have referred and that such views will be re-iterated at Potsdam, they would be galvanized into a resistance against Communist designs, which in absence of public encouragement from US, could only appear futile and hazardous to them.¹⁴⁵

As this appeal for a public declaration indicates, foreign intervention was the key to the Bulgarian political situation. Without an active American initiative, few politicians would attempt to oppose the Fatherland Front government. With it, there was a possibility that a political crisis could be promoted which would open the way to a new pattern of power within the country. Consequently, Barnes was almost frantic in his efforts to persuade Washington to come to his aid: "I am sorry to keep harping on this point . . ." he cabled on July 9.¹⁴⁶ And, again on July 30:

I realize that this is a very long telegram on what may quite naturally appear to many in the Dept as a situation very remote from real and active American interests. I report at such length in the hope of still convincing the Dept of the desirability of some public statement. . . .¹⁴⁷

The fact that the United States had not recognized the Fatherland Front government until Potsdam was enough to sustain hope of intervention. However, as the Big Three Conference drew to a close, politicians in Bulgaria began to despair of American support. In the midst of the Conference, Barnes reported:

I found Petkov still full of courage but very fearful that if no sign is forthcoming from the US and UK and particularly from US, of favorable reaction to his resistance to the [Fatherland Front] rigged elections, the independents . . . will waver in their loyalty to his leadership in this matter.¹⁴⁸

Petkov himself attempted to stimulate American intervention. On July 26 the Agrarian leader bypassed the established channels of authority under the armistice agreement and circulated an open letter to

the Prime Minister requesting postponement of the election and Allied supervision.¹⁴⁹ At this point Petkov had two complementary objectives: to weaken the authority of the Soviet-dominated Control Commission, and to bring the Western Allies into support of his position. Quite aware of the significance of Petkov's audacious challenge to the Soviet occupation authority, the Fatherland Front government was deeply disturbed. Petkov's maneuver brought forth a response indicative of the tense political situation and the anxieties of the government. The Prime Minister accused the Agrarian leader of treason: "Petkov's sin had not been merely venial but had been a mortal sin, because he had distributed copies of his letter to members of the [Allied Control Commission], thus giving the British and Americans an opportunity to intervene."¹⁵⁰

A few days later, on July 31, Petkov's resignation from the government was accepted.¹⁵¹ Barnes, reporting just as the Potsdam Conference ended, said he had hoped that Petkov's resignation would provoke a government crisis. However, without American intervention, Barnes was extremely doubtful that Petkov's lead would be followed:

I fear in absence of any encouraging signs from Washington, London and Potsdam of Anglo-American interest in Bulgarian election situation Petkov's "departure" may not be followed, as I had hoped it would be, by resignations of Stoyanov, Cheschmedjiev, Pavlov and Derzhanski. I feel very strongly that time has come when Dept must tell me what, if anything, the US Govt is really prepared to do about local political and election situation.¹⁵²

As is evident from these cables, Barnes was deeply perplexed and frustrated by the ambivalence of the American position during the period of the long delay. With no way to know of the atomic bomb and the President's plans, he greatly feared that his own initiative would not be supported. In pleading for help for Petkov he thought he was urging something which might "quite naturally appear . . . very remote from real and active American interests."¹⁵³ In fact, as we have seen, Truman had pledged an active initiative in the Balkans months earlier and, at the very moment Barnes's despairing cables reached Potsdam, Truman had already gone beyond the representative's proposals: While Barnes asked only that elections procedures be

improved, the President adamantly demanded of Stalin that the Georgiev government be changed.*

Thus, after Potsdam, Barnes found that his own views were not only sympathetically received, but that Washington was ready to intervene far more directly and actively than he could have hoped. The President's continued refusal to recognize the Georgiev government and his pointed declaration that the Balkans were not to be considered a sphere of influence for any one power (made against the background of mushroom clouds rising in the Pacific) were dramatic signals of American intentions. They transformed doubt into confidence; Bulgarian politicians who had been afraid to oppose the government without foreign support were now prepared to act.

Now all that was required was sufficient time to undertake a successful campaign against the government, and sufficient safeguards to insure that such a campaign would not be impeded. The first point involved the timing of the election. Since few politicians (except Petkov) had been prepared to criticize the government until after Truman's statement, as the August 26 election approached there had been virtually no political campaigning against Fatherland Front candidates.† As a result—with the election only three weeks off—even if conditions were absolutely free, there was little likelihood that the opposition could convey its message to the public in time to substantially affect the outcome of the poll. Only too aware of the need for prompt action, Barnes had begged for a public statement from Washington throughout July. However, Truman's need to wait for the atomic bomb had complicated the problems he faced in Bulgaria.¹⁵⁴

To make up for his own delay, therefore, the President first had to attempt to postpone the Bulgarian election to allow time for serious campaigning. Secondly, he wished to improve the election statute. And thirdly, he wished to remove the existing government so that the election would be administered by men more independent and more favorable to the West. Four days after Nagasaki, Secretary Byrnes moved speedily to the task, forcefully unveiling the full extent of the American demands. Bypassing the recognized authority of the Soviet commander under the armistice terms, on August 13, Byrnes sent an

* See above, pp. 148, 151.

Yugoslavia; see Betts, *Central and South East Europe*, pp. 58-59.

† Apparently a similar problem arose in

open letter to Prime Minister Georgiev. He demanded that the elections scheduled for August 26—now less than two weeks off—be postponed.¹⁵⁵ Byrnes also gave notice that the United States would not recognize the Bulgarian government until it had been radically re-organized:

The information available to the United States Government has not satisfied it that the first Provisional Bulgarian Government is adequately representative of the important democratic elements, of democratic opinion, or that the existing government has arranged for the scheduled elections to take place under conditions which will allow and insure the participation therein, free from the fear of force and intimidation, of all democratic elements.¹⁵⁶

Byrnes's letter (which was followed by a similar British protest),¹⁵⁷ even more than the President's statement, was an explicit attempt to influence the political situation within the country. (Truman's Balkan representative later characterized the actions as "a major diplomatic effort.")¹⁵⁸ By committing American prestige to the main demand of the opposition, the Secretary of State's maneuver threw the Fatherland Front government into a state of frenzy. Its first reaction was a futile attempt to urge the American government to stand by the commitments it had made in signing the armistice agreement. Under that agreement, the government—which, of course, had no diplomatic relations with the United States—took orders from the Soviet chairman of the Allied Control Commission.* On August 23, Georgiev's Finance Minister, Petko Stainov, publicly stated the government's position: "The British and the United States Governments should rather have submitted notes to Moscow, reached an agreement, and then advised the Bulgarian Government."¹⁵⁹

Despite this statement, the government was obviously weakened and much on the defensive. The four government ministers who had been unwilling to act without foreign help,† now told the Prime Minister that unless the elections were postponed and changes made in the electoral law, they would leave the government.¹⁶⁰ Georgiev refused to agree and accused the four of working with Barnes.¹⁶¹ On August 17, the four resigned in protest over the plans for the forthcoming elec-

* See above, pp. 134, 140-141.

† See above, p. 210.

tion.¹⁶² Georgiev countered the resignations with a firm declaration that the election would be carried out as scheduled.¹⁶³ He publicly attacked the four ministers and others who "allow themselves to be influenced by foreign powers."¹⁶⁴ New Cabinet members replaced the opposition group, and the government prepared to ride out the crisis.¹⁶⁵

With the American government and the Petkov group of opposition leaders now publicly committed, there remained only the question of what action the Soviet Union would take to uphold a government it had sponsored for more than a year. Although Stalin, hoping to persuade Truman to act with him, had not recognized Georgiev before Potsdam,¹⁶⁶ after the President's statement attacking spheres of influence, the Soviet Premier had moved quickly to give strong support to the Fatherland Front. On August 15, Radio Moscow announced that the Soviet Union would accord diplomatic recognition to Georgiev.¹⁶⁷ Two days later, Moscow announced that the famous Bulgarian Communist Georgi Dimitrov would return from the Soviet Union to participate in—and lend his prestige to—the Bulgarian elections.¹⁶⁸ The return of Dimitrov, who had become famous during the Reichstag trial, further affirmed Soviet support for the elections and the government. *Izvestia* commented that the election plans were "most democratic."¹⁶⁹

Thus the opposing positions of the various parties crystallized. "What must chiefly be regretted," observed the diplomatic correspondent of the London *Times* in Sofia, "is that a new complication is added to Allied relations. The Soviet Government has already recognized the Bulgarian Government and has sent an Ambassador to Sofia . . . A peace treaty can be made only with a recognized Government—and London and Washington appear to be committed not to recognize the Bulgarian Government. A deadlock appears inevitable."¹⁷⁰

The implications of the conflict were also noted in Britain, where preparations for the first peacetime foreign ministers' meeting were underway. "The Bulgarian situation, it is said in official circles here, is likely to produce an early deadlock in the work of the new Council of Foreign Ministers,"¹⁷¹ one American observed. Indeed, the challenge to Soviet influence in the Balkans seemed too obvious and too fundamental to permit of an easy reconciliation. The Foreign Office and others had been certain the Russians would not yield to the American

demands before Potsdam, and once Soviet support had been publicly conveyed to Georgiev's rejection of the American note, there seemed no possible way to avoid a head-on collision. The Americans were adamant and the Russians were not likely to back down. Although the Soviet commander agreed to consult Moscow again, the Allied Control Commission meeting of August 22 produced no positive results.¹⁷²

It was both a shock and a surprise, therefore, when on August 26—the very day of the election—radio Sofia interrupted its eleventh-hour appeals to voters and its denunciation of “foreign interference” to announce that the election had been postponed!¹⁷³

Truman's Balkan representative, Mark Ethridge, later boasted that the West's “determined action” had produced “remarkable results.”¹⁷⁴ At the time, British Foreign Office officials were jubilant at the sudden success, telling reporters that the Bulgarian decision eased “considerably the Anglo-Soviet-American diplomatic tension.”¹⁷⁵ Russian acquiescence in the American demand was an ignominious defeat for Soviet power in the Balkans.¹⁷⁶

The dramatic *volte-face* and Stalin's apparent willingness to cooperate also greatly heartened the opposition politicians and the American officials in Bulgaria who were confirmed not only in their judgment of the situation, but also in their estimate of their own power to affect events. The opposition now presented a list of further conditions for the election and demanded that both the Prime Minister and the Minister of Interior resign.¹⁷⁷ The United States pressed the demand that the government be reorganized, and Barnes met with government and opposition leaders to attempt to reach agreement on changes in the government and preparations for the new election.¹⁷⁸

The Georgiev government, helpless in the face of Soviet acquiescence to the Americans, could do little to repair the damage of the August 26 embarrassment. Instead, it began wholesale acceptance of various opposition proposals. Meetings were held with the American military representative and with Barnes to discuss requirements for the new election.¹⁷⁹ Pardons were granted to 302 political prisoners; another 400 had their sentences drastically reduced.¹⁸⁰ As Stalin had promised at Potsdam, American newsmen were allowed to enter the country and to report freely.¹⁸¹ All four opposition parties were legally recognized and allowed to publish newspapers.¹⁸² (It was necessary to give standing to those parties which, fearing to act with-

out American support, had previously banded together in the Fatherland Front.)¹⁸³ Mixed committees, made up mostly of schoolteachers, were designated to oversee the elections.¹⁸⁴ The government proclaimed a series of administrative steps to insure free campaigning.¹⁸⁵

In an attempt to close ranks, the government also invited the dissident opposition groups to reunite with the party leaders who had supported the Fatherland Front.¹⁸⁶ The move aimed at healing the breach between the two factions of the Agrarian and Social Democratic parties. However, the now confident opposition groups refused to reunite with their former colleagues. Instead, they demanded the dismissal of those Agrarian and Social Democratic ministers who had remained in the Cabinet,¹⁸⁷ and they began to hold public demonstrations to create public support for their position.¹⁸⁸ Once more they reiterated the demand that the Prime Minister and the Minister of the Interior resign. They now declared that unless this was agreed to, they would boycott the election.¹⁸⁹

At this point the Georgiev government balked. Moscow and Sofia had yielded to the demand that the election be postponed and had agreed to a number of reforms to insure a free campaign.* However, the proposal that the government be changed, which had been refused when Truman first raised it at Potsdam, was apparently still too much to ask. As the London Conference approached, once more the Bulgarian political situation became tense. The American-supported groups were once more more in a direct confrontation with the Soviet-backed government. “The situation, therefore, remains on dead center,” one observer noted.¹⁹⁰ Indeed, the renewed stalemate seemed even more rigidly defined than the original one had been.

Moreover, as the London Conference opened, the situation began to take on threatening overtones. Earlier, when the American demand

* Later the opposition boycotted the election, and the State Department declared that the election had not been freely conducted. However, this claim must be carefully examined, for (1) Truman's Balkan representative, who studied the problem in Bulgaria at the time, later wrote “it was by no means clear that the electoral boycott of the opposition was the best means of resolving the problem . . .”; (2) the British Foreign Office did not support the State Department's protests over the election; (3) most Western correspondents found little or

no interference in the election; (4) at almost exactly the same time the Soviet-sponsored election in Hungary (which was not boycotted by the Hungarian opposition) was conducted in a “free” manner which met the State Department's standards. (Dennett and Johnson, *Negotiating with the Russians*, p. 191; *Sunday Times*, Nov. 18, 1945; *Christian Science Monitor*, Nov. 20, 1945; *Ibid.*, Sept. 20, 24; Oct. 12, 16, 17, 18; Nov. 17, 1945; Seton-Watson, *The East European Revolution*, p. 193; Betts, *Central and South East Europe*, p. 105.)

for a postponement of the elections had been received only four days after Nagasaki, there were scattered comments about the role of the atomic bomb in America's new-found "firmness."* Now, as the United States pressed the demand that the government be changed, mass meetings filled the streets of Sofia with defiant, repeated chants of "We don't fear the atomic bomb!"¹⁹¹

Thus, the fact that the atomic bomb had imparted an entirely new sense of confidence to American diplomacy was quickly recognized and interpreted in the most unfavorable light; it appeared as a menacing force—in brief, a threat. There were now also doubts as to the actual power of American diplomacy. It appeared that the diplomatic successes could only be attributed to the atomic bomb, for once it had been demonstrated, points at issue in Manchuria, Hungary, and Bulgaria which had not been yielded at Potsdam had now been accepted by the Russians. But now the failure to change the Bulgarian government seemed a sign that the diplomatic offensive which had scored so brilliantly might be losing its force. It remained to be seen to what extent Soviet policy would yield in a country far more vital to it than Hungary or Bulgaria.

DEADLOCK IN RUMANIA

EVEN CHURCHILL HAD DISTINGUISHED between the three ex-satellite countries, allocating, in the first instance, Soviet influence of "50 per cent" in Hungary, "75 per cent" in Bulgaria, and a full "90 per cent" in Rumania.† Though these figures had been modified in the bargaining process, from the Soviet point of view Rumania was obviously the most important Balkan country. Rumania occupied a key strategic position athwart the southwestern invasion route to Russia. Bulgaria had been able to wage war against the Soviet Union for only twenty-four hours;¹⁹² but Rumania, in alliance with Hitler, had sent twenty-six divisions against the Soviets, devastating Russian territory, and penetrating as far into the interior as Stalingrad.¹⁹³ Moreover, Rumanians harbored traditional anti-Russian sentiments and were therefore more likely to use their strategic geographic position against the Soviet Union in any future hostilities.¹⁹⁴

* See above, p. 204.

† See above, p. 133.

American policy, however, recognized no distinctions in the Balkans.* In Rumania, too, American leaders had long planned to take the initiative to change the government. The demonstration of the atomic bomb and the end of the long wait meant that these plans could now be implemented. Here, as elsewhere, the first move in the diplomatic offensive was Truman's attack upon spheres of influence—a declaration which gave heart to conservative politicians in Rumania as it had in Bulgaria. Here there was even greater excitement for, unlike Bulgaria, in Rumania the deep tradition of anti-Russian feeling had been increased, not diminished, by war propaganda and the defeat suffered at Russian hands.¹⁹⁵

Even during the spring, while the war was still on, among Peasant and Liberal leaders there was a constant hope that somehow the Western powers would come to their assistance. According to one American in the country at the time, "they were wholeheartedly anti-Russian, and a good many of their members continued to assume that the Western Allies would somehow intervene."¹⁹⁶ Although it seems that a number of conservatives had been offered posts in the Groza government, they had apparently refused to join the government after a dispute over estimates of their relative importance in the domestic political balance.¹⁹⁷ The leading politician in the conservative ranks, the seventy-year-old Iuliu Maniu, leader of the Peasant party (a figure corresponding roughly to Petkov in Bulgaria), had retired from chairmanship of his party two weeks after Groza took office.¹⁹⁸

However, Maniu, like Petkov in Bulgaria, did not retire from active participation in politics. As Potsdam approached and the powers continued to withhold recognition, Maniu and his associates also hoped

* As many observers have pointed out, Byrnes never seemed to understand a dilemma inherent in his policy. There is no reason to doubt his numerous assurances that in urging free elections and new governments he had no wish to support governments hostile to the Soviet Union; nevertheless, as Roberts has written, "a popularly elected Government [in Rumania] would in all probability be anti-Soviet." Thus, inevitably Byrnes's idealistic policy must have seemed a threat to the Russians. (Roberts, *Rumania*, p. 269.)

On the viability of democratic government in Rumania, see also the views cabled to the War Department by its representative in Bucharest shortly before Potsdam: "Even

under normal peacetime conditions, a representative government in Rumania would find it difficult to maintain itself in power. Rumanians have had no experience in democracy for over ten years, and the ability of members of any coalition government to work in harmony for the common goal, regardless of personal or party problems must be open to question." (*Conference of Berlin*, I, p. 397. For additional views, see Wolff, *The Balkans in Our Time*, p. 286; McNeill, *America, Britain and Russia, 1941-46*, pp. 698-701; Allen, *Great Britain and the United States*, p. 872; Williams, *The Tragedy of American Diplomacy*, pp. 258-59.)

that the Soviet-sponsored government might be changed.¹⁹⁹ Because of the strength of anti-Russian sentiment in the country, they could go farther than Petkov in Slavophilic Bulgaria. The Peasant and Liberal parties decided to organize demonstrations to show that opposition to the National Democratic Front government was an effective force. They also hoped to forestall a Potsdam decision to recognize Groza or a slightly altered government.²⁰⁰

In open violation of the specific terms of the armistice, on July 18 Maniu boldly began his political offensive with a speech to university students demanding that the Groza government be dismissed: "The country must no longer tolerate dictatorial governments imposed from abroad."²⁰¹ The speech was followed by a brief demonstration in the Palace Square.²⁰² Two days later, Constantin Bratianu addressed about seven hundred members of his Liberal party's youth organization in the same vein.²⁰³ Following his speech, a larger demonstration and parade took place.²⁰⁴ This time the protesting demonstrators were met by Communists and others who supported the government. A brief struggle between the two groups took place and two people were injured and approximately thirty-two were arrested.²⁰⁵

The acting American representative in Bucharest, Roy Melbourne, reported that the Groza government was greatly disturbed by the demonstrations.²⁰⁶ A hastily summoned conference between party leaders and the National Democratic Front evidenced increasing anxiety over the internal and the international situation. The hopes of the Peasants and Liberals, and the fears of the government, were directed toward Potsdam. The opposition apparently believed that the Big Three might eliminate the Groza government and open the way for new elections. Groups within the government too, according to Melbourne, were "expecting Cabinet changes and fearing shifts detriment[al]" to the National Democratic Front position.²⁰⁷

As in Bulgaria, the internal political situation was ruled not only by the relative strengths of the various political factions, but by the role the big powers played—or might be expected to play. In the midst of the Potsdam meeting, Maniu sought an interview with Melbourne in Bucharest to report that "he had counseled his party that U.S. and Great Britain . . . could secure Soviet acquiescence to a democratic interpretation of Yalta."²⁰⁸ He said that in his belief the National

Peasants could confidently expect an overwhelming electoral majority if free elections were held.²⁰⁹ He urged that Groza be removed from office so that a new government would supervise the elections.²¹⁰ He asked the War, Interior, and Propaganda ministries for his own party. The National Peasant party could be expected to be impartial, he explained, since "it would be to its interest to conduct the elections in an unbiased manner. . . . An inevitable large National Peasant majority" would emerge in any event.²¹¹

Having made his proposal, Maniu went on to hint at the possible consequences if he failed to achieve his aims. If the Groza government was retained, he stated, his party would organize energetic country-wide opposition, including demonstrations. According to Melbourne, "in measured words he said that for such . . . action he was certain of support from the dissatisfied Rumanian peasants who would unite with the townspeople. . . ."²¹²

In view of earlier Rumanian riots and bloodshed (even during the war),* there were ominous overtones in this statement. In fact, it contained the distinct hint of a threat and offered the prospect of violent disturbances. The "measured words" meant that the opposition could, if it so chose, create an unstable and dangerous situation. Earlier, one reason Churchill had proposed his spheres-of-influence arrangement to Stalin was his knowledge that political feelings ran so high in Rumania and Greece that civil war was a very real possibility—especially if the powers began to support different factions.²¹³ In Greece, where anti-British feeling had already resulted in a short outburst of civil war in December 1944,† and in Rumania where riots and violence had been suppressed just before Groza's appointment in the spring of 1945, Churchill's judgment was apparently a fair assessment of realities. Maniu's statement did no more than recall and confirm this earlier estimate. Shortly thereafter, Molotov affirmed the same view, telling Byrnes that Rumanian politics could easily erupt into a civil war if the powers did not concert their policies.²¹⁴

Maniu undoubtedly made his statement in the hope of forcing a

* These precipitated the Soviet intervention discussed on p. 136.
† See above, p. 134.

more explicit American commitment to his cause. However, during the summer of delay, and at the time of the Potsdam Conference, the American representative could give the Peasant leader very little direct encouragement. Like his colleague in Bulgaria, he did not know to what extent Truman was prepared to press the matter. Nor did he know of the atomic bomb. As soon as the Conference ended without recognition of the Groza government, however, the opposition had its signal.²¹⁵ And, as in Bulgaria, the series of speeches denouncing spheres of influence and "police governments" sparked tremendous political activity within the country.

In Rumania, the attack upon the Soviet-sponsored government centered around, and was led by, the young King Michael. The King had already secretly asked for American help before Potsdam.²¹⁶ Now, privately encouraged to act by American representatives,²¹⁷ Michael publicly demanded that Groza resign.²¹⁸ He then bypassed the Allied Control Commission and appealed directly to the three Allied powers to help him form a new government.²¹⁹ Adding emphasis to his demand, the King gave notice that until a new government was formed, he would refuse to sign government decrees.²²⁰ Shortly thereafter, the Minister of Finance resigned. Michael seized the opportunity and, refusing to authorize the appointment of a replacement, made it impossible to pay the salaries of government employees.²²¹ Michael also refused to appear at important public celebrations, and, in a dramatic gesture of opposition, he left Bucharest to wait for the elimination of the Groza government.²²²

Melbourne let Michael know that if he persisted the United States would support him,²²³ and Byrnes immediately responded to the King's appeal. On August 22, the Secretary of State met with representatives of the press, welcomed Michael's request for help to replace Groza, and pledged official American support for efforts to change the government. The United States would gladly lend "assistance with a view to the formation of a government, which, according to the report of the Conference of Berlin, might be recognized by the principal powers," Byrnes declared.²²⁴ The Secretary of State's favorable response confirmed the American intention to bypass the Allied Control Commission and it publicly committed the United States to the demand that the Groza government be changed.

Some observers noted that the initial Soviet decision to yield to "the

firmness of the Western Allies" in Bulgaria had given the American and British governments confidence in their approach to Rumania.²²⁵ Though undoubtedly the first success in Bulgaria confirmed American leaders' estimates of their ability to force the Soviet hand in the Balkans, as we have seen, Truman and Byrnes had decided to intervene to remove the Soviet "blackout" many months earlier. During the period of the long wait, and at Potsdam, they had made their intentions quite clear and had also told Stalin that they would not yield on their demand that the Rumanian government be changed.

Thus, implementing their earlier plans, and now apparently quite confident of the wisdom of their course and their power to pursue it successfully, throughout August, American leaders pressed the attempt to remove Groza from office. As the London Conference of Foreign Ministers neared, however, no sign of Soviet willingness to yield appeared as it had in Bulgaria. Apparently the Russians felt that Rumania was different and, in fact, they had already indicated differences in attitudes toward the two countries.

Immediately after Potsdam (on August 4), Moscow had hastened to accord diplomatic recognition to Bucharest, although it was two weeks later—and only in the brief period before yielding to American demands—that Moscow had accorded the same recognition to Sofia.²²⁶ Thus, even before the new American effort in Rumania, the Soviet Union had declared its commitment to Groza. After Michael's appeal and Byrnes's response to it, Moscow again promptly and dramatically demonstrated that it was not prepared to yield easily in Rumania. *Izvestia* criticized "some foreign newspapers" for their antagonism to Groza.²²⁷ The Soviet-supported government announced a campaign against "hirelings of the former Premier Radescu." Twenty "terrorists" were arrested for attempting to overthrow the government. Those who were "trying to create discord among the United Nations and seeking foreign support for the realization of their personal political ambitions" were castigated by the government.²²⁸

On August 28, it was announced that the Soviet envoy in Rumania had been raised to the rank of full ambassador.²²⁹ A week before the London Conference, Groza and his Deputy Prime Minister Tatarescu were invited to Moscow, where they were given celebrity treatment, including a state dinner by Stalin.²³⁰ On September 4, the Soviet Union refused a proposal by Byrnes for consultations on the basis of

King Michael's appeal.²³¹ At the same time, Groza issued a bitter statement from Moscow attacking Maniu and Bratianu for their role in the crisis:

Maniu and Bratianu have lost all contact with the realities of present-day political life in Rumania. They endeavor to provoke a Government crisis by artificial means and to sow discord between the Government and the people on the one hand, and the Head of State, King Michael, on the other, by recommending him to actions harmful to the national interest and to the crown.²³²

The following day, *Izvestia* accused Britain and America of trying to force Groza out of office, specifically identifying the local representatives of the two powers as prime movers in Michael's maneuver. Giving notice that the Soviet Union would hold to its support of Groza, *Izvestia* commented:

American and British representatives began to insist on the resignation of the Rumanian Government without first placing the matter before the Allied Control Commission, thereby violating established procedure in the work of the Commission. If this is called implementation of a coordinated Allied policy, what might be called unilateral acts violating the coordination of Allied policy? . . . The viewpoint of Soviet public opinion is quite clear. It firmly maintains that interference . . . is inadmissible.²³³

Stalin now gave further evidence of his commitment to Groza, sending the Rumanian Premier back to his country with numerous politically useful concessions. Groza received promises of a Soviet loan of 150,000 tons of grain, the return of railroads to Rumanian direction, the return of a number of locomotives, railway freight cars, merchant ships, and even a few warships. Moreover, the Rumanian Premier was able to bring back from Moscow an agreement to reduce the reparations burden and a pledge to repatriate immediately all prisoners of war. Finally, Stalin agreed that Soviet troops stationed in Rumania would help reconstruct towns destroyed in the war.²³⁴

In this way, Moscow underscored its intention to stand by Groza on the eve of the London Conference. Now Britain and the United States on the one hand, and the Soviet Union on the other, were publicly committed to diametrically opposed positions in Rumania. Within the country, the opposition and the Groza government were similarly

committed and, as London approached, Maniu and Bratianu burned their bridges behind them, openly attacking the Soviet Union in direct contravention of the armistice.²³⁵

TOWARD A TEST OF STRENGTH

THUS, ON THE EVE of the first peacetime meeting of the foreign ministers, the American offensive in the Balkans, which had been met by initial Soviet willingness to compromise, now had reached major obstacles in both Bulgaria and Rumania. The over-all question first posed in April and again at Potsdam was still the same: Did the United States have the power to force Soviet acquiescence to its demands deep within the Soviet area of influence? From the early summer American leaders had been convinced that, once demonstrated, the atomic bomb would permit them to demand major changes in the border areas of the Soviet Union. But now this conviction would be tested, and the relative power of the United States and the Soviet Union defined, when the foreign ministers met on September 10.

As Secretary Byrnes prepared to leave for London, the various instruments of diplomacy which had not been actively employed during the summer of delay were now again readied for use. Although neither the President nor the Secretary of State had discussed a large-scale credit with Soviet representatives since the late-April showdown, now, after the atomic bomb had been demonstrated, they were prepared to negotiate. At a meeting with the President and the Secretary of State shortly after the Japanese surrender, Leo Crowley urged that the Lend-Lease cutoff—first attempted, then repealed in May—should now be firmly implemented. Once again, though his recommendation was based upon the law's requirement that Lend-Lease cease at the end of hostilities, and though it would have implications for all the Allies, Crowley made it clear that the primary advantage of immediate action was that it would force the Soviet Union to look for other means to pay for American material assistance. Both the President and the Secretary of State agreed with Crowley, and Truman authorized him to act promptly.*²³⁶ After Lend-Lease shipments were

* See Byrnes, *All in One Lifetime*, pp. 309-10, for a report which indicates that the primary reason for the timing of the

August cutoff—like the May cutoff—was the desire to force the Soviet Union into a de- (Continued on next page)

halted on August 22, the Russians were informed that the Export-Import Bank would consider an application for a large credit. It was soon made clear that they would be expected to offer, as *quid pro quo*, concessions in Eastern and Southeastern Europe.²³⁷

Similarly, throughout the summer Truman and his advisers had regarded the presence of conventional troops as vital to their European diplomacy. The atomic bomb, as Stimson had expected, had helped stabilize the situation by ending the war long before redeployment had substantially weakened American strength on the Continent.* But now, looking to the future when demobilization would drain troops from Europe, Truman moved swiftly to attempt to preserve his position; on August 17—the third day of peace—he publicly declared his intention to ask Congressional approval for a universal-military-training program for all able-bodied young men.²³⁸ On the eve of the London Conference he gave details of his proposals for peace, telling an August 31 Cabinet meeting “that the time had come to initiate a new military policy. If we were to maintain leadership among other nations, we must continue to be strong in a military way.”†²³⁹

But, as before, economic aid and the presence of conventional troops were the least important elements in the American diplomatic posture. Throughout the summer the expectation of the atomic bomb had dominated diplomatic strategy. Now, in late August, as Byrnes prepared for his meeting in London, the Secretary of State made it clear that the bomb continued to play a predominant role in his calculations. In a long discussion with Byrnes, Assistant Secretary of War McCloy found him “quite radically opposed to any approach to Stalin whatever” to attempt to establish international control of

atomic energy—“He was on the point of departing for the Foreign Ministers’ meeting and wished to have the implied threat of the bomb in his pocket during the conference. . . .”²⁴⁰

And two days before sailing for London, Byrnes discussed the central role of the atomic bomb in his diplomacy with Secretary Stimson:

Jim Byrnes had not yet gone abroad and I had a very good talk with him afterwards sitting in the White House hall . . . I took up the question which I had been working at with McCloy up in St. Hubert’s, namely how to handle Russia with the big bomb. I found that Byrnes was very much against any attempt to cooperate with Russia. His mind is full of his problems with the coming meeting of foreign ministers and he looks to having the presence of the bomb in his pocket, so to speak, as a great weapon to get through the thing. . . .²⁴¹

In this frame of mind Secretary of State Byrnes sailed for his first peacetime encounter with a representative of the Soviet Union. Since early April, the President and his senior advisers had focused their attention on political and economic conditions in Eastern Europe; they had never lost their active interest in reducing or eliminating Soviet influence in the area. In April the President had been able to back his diplomacy only with large-scale credits and the presence of the American army in Europe. Advised that there was much to gain if he would wait for the atomic bomb, Truman had decided to postpone a showdown over Eastern Europe.

Now, as Admiral Leahy has written, “it was no longer a theory. We had the bombs.”²⁴² The firm approach so long in suspense could be resumed with the backing of unprecedented military power. For the first time since April, Secretary Byrnes was ready for a meeting with Molotov to discuss affairs in the Soviet zone of Europe. His immediate objective which, like the April showdown over Poland, was to have symbolic implications for all of Eastern Europe, was to force a change in the Balkan governments. The Secretary of State was extremely confident of success.²⁴³ His meeting was to be, as he later wrote, “in a very real sense, a test of strength.”²⁴⁴

(Continued from preceding page)

pendent position in the next round of credit negotiations. And, as in May, the President apparently was not guided primarily by a belief that the legal provisions required immediate and unequivocal action, for he made a number of exceptions to the Lend-Lease cutoff. For a report of these, see McNeill, *America, Britain and Russia, 1941-46*, p. 785.

* See above, p. 117.

† Congress rejected Truman’s proposal. Harriman was later to argue that this was the primary reason American diplomacy failed to achieve its European objectives:

“Only by keeping our military forces in being after Germany and Japan surrendered could we have attempted to compel the Soviet Union to withdraw from the territory it controlled. . . .” (*Congressional Record*, Aug. 27, 1951, p. A5416; emphasis added.) Similarly, Truman has written: “I am morally certain that if Congress had gone into the [military training] program thoroughly in 1945, when I first recommended it, we would have had a pool of basically trained men which would have made the Soviets hesitate in their program of expansion in certain strategic parts of the world.” (*Year of Decisions*, pp. 511-12.)

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One factor that was to change a lot of ideas, including my own, was the atom bomb . . .

—ADMIRAL WILLIAM D. LEAHY
CHIEF OF STAFF
TO THE PRESIDENT

BYRNES FIRMLY PRESSED his demand that the Bulgarian and Rumanian governments be changed, but when Molotov refused to yield at London, the first peacetime meeting of foreign ministers broke down completely—it was impossible even to agree upon a joint protocol recording the failure.* The initial climax of the post-Hiroshima struggle was a continued and open deadlock. "We had come to the crossroads," Byrnes recalls.¹ In forcing a public break over the issue, the Secretary of State's action was intended to be symbolic. As in the Polish dispute in April, American policy aimed not only at a favorable resolution of the specific points at issue, but at a reconsideration of fundamental political and economic arrangements throughout the Soviet-controlled zone of Europe—"Only by refusing to bow to Soviet domination could we establish sound relations for the future."²

Byrnes has written that "our attitude was a shock to them," and it is certain, as both he and John Foster Dulles (who assisted the Secretary of State at London) have emphasized, that postwar Soviet-American tension must be dated from the London Conference.³ It is also undoubtedly true that the atomic bomb not only influenced the attitude American policy makers took in their approach to the confrontation,

* Technically, the Conference broke down over a procedural issue, but as Byrnes has written, in reality, "the chief cause" was the dispute over the governments of Rumania and Bulgaria. (*Speaking Frankly*, pp. 104-8;

see also, Senate Committee on Foreign Relations, *A Decade of American Foreign Policy, 1941-49*, p. 55; Leahy Diary, Sept. 23, 1945, p. 163.)

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but also, as Prime Minister Attlee cabled to President Truman at the time, the weapon completely overshadowed the discussions.⁴

The political developments after August 1945, like the later (mid-1946), ill-fated attempts to control atomic energy, cannot here be analyzed.* And, unfortunately, Admiral Leahy's summary judgment that the Cold War began in the Balkans can only be tested with further research.⁵ However, at this point the major conclusions to be drawn from a study of American policy during the first five months of the Truman administration can be briefly summarized. It is also possible to attempt to define certain other problems which, with presently available materials, can be stated but cannot be conclusively resolved.

The most important point is the most general: Contrary to a commonly held view, it is abundantly clear that the atomic bomb profoundly influenced the way American policy makers viewed political problems. Or, as Admiral Leahy has neatly summarized the point, "One factor that was to change a lot of ideas, including my own, was the atom bomb . . ."⁶ The change caused by the new weapon was quite specific. It did not produce American opposition to Soviet policies in Eastern Europe and Manchuria. Rather, since a consensus had already been reached on the need to take a firm stand against the Soviet Union in both areas, the atomic bomb *confirmed* American leaders in their judgment that they had sufficient power to affect developments in the border regions of the Soviet Union. There is both truth and precision in Truman's statement to Stimson that the weapon "gave him an entirely new feeling of confidence."⁷

This effect was a profoundly important one. Before the atomic bomb was tested, despite their desire to oppose Soviet policies, Western policy makers harbored very grave doubts that Britain and America could challenge Soviet predominance in Eastern Europe. Neither Roosevelt nor Truman could have confidence that the American public would permit the retention of large numbers of conventional troops in Europe after the war. (And Congressional rejection of Truman's

* The official history of the Atomic Energy Commission demonstrates how Byrnes opposed later attempts to control atomic energy, and how he finally agreed to approach the Russians with a control plan

only after being assured that the proposal would guarantee continued American production of atomic weapons for some years. (Hewlett and Anderson, *The New World*, pp. 417, 456, 459-60, and especially 461.)

military-training program later confirmed the pessimistic wartime predictions.) Thus, at the time of the Yalta Conference, as Assistant Secretary of State William L. Clayton advised Secretary Stettinius, "a large credit . . . appear[ed] to be the only concrete bargaining lever for use in connection with the many other political and economic problems which will arise between our two countries."⁸

That this lever of diplomacy was not sufficiently powerful to force Soviet acceptance of American proposals was amply demonstrated during the late-April and early-May crisis over Poland. Despite Truman's judgment that "the Russians needed us more than we needed them,"⁹ Stalin did not yield to the firm approach. Hence, without the atomic bomb it seemed exceedingly doubtful that American policy makers would be able substantially to affect events within the Soviet-occupied zone of Europe. It may well be that, had there been no atomic bomb, Truman would have been forced to reconsider the basic direction of his policy as Churchill had done some months earlier.

Indeed, Churchill's 1944 estimate of the power realities usefully illuminates the problems faced by Western policy makers as they attempted to judge their relative strength vis-à-vis the Soviet Union. As soon as Roosevelt rejected Churchill's desperate pleas for an invasion through the Balkans, the Prime Minister understood that he would have little power in Southeastern Europe, and that, indeed, the British position in Greece was seriously threatened. As he told Roosevelt, "the only way I can prevent [utter anarchy] is by persuading the Russians to quit boosting [the Communist-oriented] E.A.M."¹⁰ Again, there was overwhelming logic in his parallel 1944 argument: "It seems to me, considering the Russians are about to invade Rumania in great force . . . it would be a good thing to follow the Soviet leadership, considering that neither you nor we have any troops there at all and that they will probably do what they like anyhow."¹¹ As he later recalled, before the atomic test, "the arrangements made about the Balkans were, I was sure, the best possible."¹²

As I have attempted to show, by the time of the Yalta Conference, somewhat reluctantly, and against the wishes of the State Department, Roosevelt came to the same conclusion. Even the State Department was forced to adopt the official view that "this Government probably would not oppose predominant Soviet influence in [Poland and the Balkans]."¹³ And one high-ranking official went beyond this judgment; substituting his concern for Western Europe for the Prime Minister's

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specific fears about Greece, he stated: "I am willing to sponsor and support the Soviet arguments if it will save . . . the rest of Europe from the diplomacy of the jungle which is almost certain to ensue otherwise."¹⁴ As Truman's Balkan representative recalled the Yalta Conference, it was "fateful that these discussions should have been held at a time when Soviet bargaining power in eastern Europe was so much stronger than that of the western allies."¹⁵ But it remained for Byrnes to summarize the early-1945 relative strengths of the powers: "It was not a question of what we would *let* the Russians do, but what we could *get* them to do."¹⁶

As I have shown, this appraisal was radically changed by the summer of 1945. Since Byrnes advised Truman on both the atomic bomb and the need for strong opposition to the Russians in Eastern Europe before the President's first confrontation with Molotov, the new weapon's first impact possibly can be seen as early as the April showdown.* However, no final judgment can be rendered on this point, using the evidence presently available. But there is no question that by the middle of July leading American policy makers were convinced that the atomic bomb would permit the United States to take a "firm" stand in subsequent negotiations. In fact, American leaders felt able to demand *more* at Potsdam than they had asked at Yalta. Again, Churchill's post-atomic appraisal is in striking contrast to his view of the pre-atomic realities: "We now had something in our hands which would redress the balance with the Russians."¹⁷ And Byrnes's new advice to Truman was quite straightforward: "The bomb might well put us in a position to dictate our own terms. . . ."¹⁸

Once the profound impact of the atomic bomb upon American judgments is recognized, considerable light is cast upon the complicated events of the summer of 1945. The curious reversals in American Polish policy and the Hopkins mission both become understandable. The period is one in which two groups of officials debated strategy. Although there were differences of emphasis, since all agreed on the broad objective of attempting to force the Soviet Union into cooperative relationships in Eastern and Central Europe, the real struggle was over timing. Those outside the War Department who had little knowledge or little faith in the as yet untested atomic weapon argued that an immediate showdown was necessary. In this their views

* See above, p. 111/n

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paralleled Churchill's, who, having come to terms on the Balkans, feared a further weakening of Western determination, combined with a withdrawal of American troops, would convince Stalin time was on his side if he dug in while the West melted away.¹⁹

Secretary Stimson, however, was able to counter this argument in two ways: He was able to show that conventional strength on the Continent would not be substantially reduced during the two months' delay until the atomic test; and he was able to promise that if a confrontation could be postponed the United States would soon be possessed of "decisive" powers.²⁰ After forcing a premature showdown on the symbolic Polish issue, Truman reversed himself and accepted Stimson's broad strategy. The price he paid for delay was not high; he was forced to yield the substance of the point at issue in the Polish controversy, and he had to withdraw American troops to the agreed zonal positions in Germany. Significantly, he later characterized his first attempt to utilize economic bargaining strength through the Lend-Lease cutoff as a "mistake."²¹ From Truman's point of view, not only was the first showdown badly timed, but the need to reverse his public position and to send Hopkins on a mission of conciliation must have been a great personal embarrassment.

However, it is vital to recognize that Truman's conciliatory actions during late May, June, and early July did not represent his basic policy. He had demonstrated in the April showdown and in the decision to maintain American troop positions in Germany that his view of how to treat with Russia was far different from Roosevelt's. His decision abruptly to cut off Lend-Lease, his show of force over the Trieste dispute, his reconsideration of Roosevelt's Far Eastern agreement, his breach of the Balkans understandings, his refusal to adhere to the Yalta reparations accord—all these acts testify to the great gulf between his view and the view of his predecessor.

Those who argue that "Mr. Truman intended to continue the policy laid down by President Roosevelt"*²² have focused attention on an extremely brief period when Truman did indeed adopt a more moder-

* Woodward, whose statement I have quoted, uncritically follows Truman's claim: "I stood squarely behind all commitments and agreements entered into by our late great President and . . . I would do every-

thing I could to follow along that path." (*Year of Decisions*, pp. 75-76.) Feis makes the same mistake: "Truman felt faithful to the ideas and ideals of the war leader . . ." (*Churchill, Roosevelt, Stalin*, pp. 599-600.)

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ate approach. But his actions during this period—symbolized by his attempt to avoid the appearance of “ganging up” with Britain against the Soviet Union—were only a manifestation of his tactical retreat. In a fundamental sense, even the conciliatory period can only be explained by recognizing that its primary purpose was not to continue Roosevelt’s policy, but to facilitate a far different policy based upon the overwhelming power soon to be available. Truman replaced the symbolic April showdown over Poland with a parallel August and September effort in the Balkans. Both before and after the brief conciliatory period, the President’s attitude is best summed up in the statement he made eight days after Roosevelt’s death: He “intended to be firm with the Russians and make no concessions.”²³ And both before and after the temporary period of no “ganging up,” Truman’s effort to coordinate policy with Britain was a hallmark of his approach. As Byrnes has written, Molotov’s conclusion that American policy had changed after Roosevelt’s death was “understandable.”²⁴

The Potsdam meeting clearly illustrates how the strategic decision to wait for the atomic bomb dominated American policy making from mid-May until early August. The primary reason most Western leaders began to call for another meeting with Stalin only three months after Yalta was their desire to have a confrontation on the important European questions then in tense dispute. But, as I have shown, Truman rejected the advice of his advisers and Churchill, and twice postponed a face-to-face meeting with Stalin because of his decision to wait for the atomic bomb. Ironically, however, in the end he committed himself to a meeting which was still a scant two weeks too early to be decisive. For this reason, to focus attention on the Potsdam meeting itself, as many writers have done,* is to completely misunderstand American policy. Indeed, the interesting question is not what happened at the meeting, but why very little happened at all.

Thus, the importance of the atomic bomb in American calculations is underscored by the negative result of the heads-of-government meeting; had the new weapon not played such a crucial role in American strategy, there would have been every reason for Truman to

* Note how both Woodward and Feis conclude their studies (*British Foreign Policy* and *Between War and Peace*) with the

Potsdam Conference, rather than the immediate post-conference diplomacy.

attempt to achieve a negotiated settlement as quickly as possible after the defeat of Germany. Assuming, as Churchill did until mid-July, that it was unwise to gamble on the possibilities of the as yet untested weapon, the Prime Minister was undoubtedly correct to argue that "the decisive, practical points of strategy" involved "*above all*, that a settlement must be reached on all major issues between the West and the East . . . *before the armies of democracy melted* . . ." As he told Eden, the "issue . . . seems to me to dwarf all others."²⁵ Without the atomic bomb, Churchill believed, the only hope lay in an "early and speedy showdown."²⁶

Just as he had hurried to arrange an understanding in the Balkans before the Russian position became overwhelmingly powerful in late 1944, he now searched for ways "we may be able to please them . . . as part of a general settlement."²⁷ Churchill sought to establish a *modus vivendi* before American conventional strength disappeared from the Continent. He wished to give priority to the German question, to recognize the Balkan governments, to settle all frontier issues, to complete the peace treaties quickly and to give only secondary attention to establishing new machinery for post-Potsdam discussions.²⁸

Until the atomic test report arrived, Churchill must have thought it incomprehensible that the Americans were not interested in a negotiated settlement. Though they wished to state their case on all issues in dispute, the American delegation was far more concerned with establishing a Council to take up unsettled questions than they were in serious negotiations while the heads of government were together.²⁹ Thus, significantly, London met with no success in a pre-Potsdam effort to convince Washington of the seemingly obvious point that the German issue was more important than the procedural matter of arranging for new meetings of the foreign ministers.³⁰

As we have seen, once the detailed report of the atomic test arrived at Potsdam, Churchill reversed himself completely: "We were . . . possessed of powers which were irresistible."³¹ But Churchill's pre-Potsdam appraisal of Stalin's position was probably correct; for, unless the West was prepared to negotiate a settlement, the Soviet Premier undoubtedly calculated there was everything to gain if he waited until the American troops were withdrawn from the Conti-

ment.* Since Truman did not tell Stalin of the atomic bomb, it could not yet be expected to play a major role in Soviet-American relations. And, indeed, with no apparent changes in the power relationships, on most issues discussed at the Conference, *both* Truman and Stalin held their ground. The Potsdam Conference took place at a unique moment in history, when each side undoubtedly believed time was on its side. The logic of the situation ensured—as the final protocol showed—that the Conference could only end in deadlock.

Undoubtedly Soviet intelligence knew generally of the work being done on the atomic bomb. However, it is probable that Stalin had no specific knowledge of the New Mexico test—or that if he knew of it, he did not know in detail how greatly it had exceeded expectations. His post-Hiroshima reversals in Manchuria, Hungary, and Bulgaria testify to a new conviction that the power realities required him to yield considerably more than he may have originally thought necessary. It is probable that Truman had this in mind when he noted that by early September “our possession of the secret of harnessing atomic energy already had far-reaching effects on our relations with other nations.”³²

Undoubtedly the best concise summary of the position taken by the West at Potsdam has been provided by General de Gaulle: “The Americans and British hoped to recover in application what they had conceded in principle.” De Gaulle believed that “the rapidity of the Sovietization [of Eastern Europe] was only the inevitable result of what had been agreed upon at the Crimea Conference.”³³ For this reason, although he strongly opposed the Yalta decisions, de Gaulle felt that “the regrets the British and Americans now expressed [at Potsdam] were quite uncalled for.”³⁴ He concluded that “there was every reason to foresee that on no issue would the Potsdam Conference realize any durable entente”; and that there would be “unlimited friction between the Soviet and Anglo-American participants.”³⁵

Truman would not have agreed with this judgment. He believed that the United States had sufficient power to force Soviet acceptance of the American plan for lasting world peace. Above all, his policy

* Compare Deutscher: By the time of the Potsdam Conference “Stalin’s figure loomed incomparably larger on the European horizon.” And “Stalin may have reckoned with

a more or less rapid withdrawal of American power from the Continent and consequently with the further growth of Russian predominance.” (*Stalin*, p. 532.)

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required a stable Europe based upon democratic governments and a sound Continental economy. There were two fundamental reasons why the President believed the atomic bomb would permit him to implement his plan: On the one hand, after a new symbolic show-down, the bomb seemed likely to force Soviet agreement to American economic and political plans for Eastern Europe; and, on the other, its power meant that there was no need to fear another German revival—the German economic contribution to Continental stability could be given priority over industrial disarmament schemes.

Truman's own argument that a stable Europe was vital to world peace and to American security reveals the error of the common opinion that America had little active interest in European affairs until the 1947 Truman Doctrine and Marshall Plan. The President's mid-1945 declaration to his staff was an accurate statement of American policy: "We were committed to the rehabilitation of Europe, and there was to be no abandonment this time."³⁶ Indeed, much more must be said, for the American commitment to Europe was not restricted to the Western regions of the Continent. As George F. Kennan, the author of the "containment policy," has emphasized, American policy was "by no means limited to holding the line."³⁷ And as Byrnes has repeatedly stressed, in 1945 and 1946 senior American officials were not primarily concerned with a Soviet political or military threat to Western Europe;³⁸ their eyes were focused on conditions in the Soviet-occupied zone. Byrnes has been quite explicit; his policy always aimed at forcing the Russians to yield in Eastern Europe, and in mid-1947 he still continued to argue that the United States had it in its power to force the Russians to "retire in a very decent manner."³⁹

There is no question that Byrnes's policy derived from the best

* Compare Harriman's previously quoted remark that only the lack of sufficient conventional forces made it impossible "to compel the Soviet Union to withdraw." (*Congressional Record*, Aug. 27, 1951, p. A5416.)

By the time the President accepted his resignation in early 1947, Byrnes had not achieved his objective. Though the Red Army had indeed withdrawn from Manchuria, Iran, Hungary, and Czechoslovakia, measured by his own standard he was a failure as Secretary of State—American policy had not been able to force Soviet withdrawal from the rest of Eastern Europe.

Byrnes left office complaining that the Russians "don't scare." With straightforward logic that illuminated the consistency of his basic view and the ironic tragedy of his idealism, he then attempted to convince his fellow countrymen that "measures of the last resort" were the only way to secure lasting world peace. As is often forgotten, Byrnes, who recently endorsed the Presidential candidacy of Senator Goldwater, was perhaps the most highly placed of those who urged a "preventive war" to force the Russians out of Europe. (Forrestal *Diaries*, p. 262; Byrnes, *Speaking Frankly*, p. 203.)

intentions and the highest ideals. And there is no reason to doubt Truman's statement that "the one purpose which dominated me in everything I thought and did was to prevent a third world war."⁴⁰ Nevertheless, the attempt to force Soviet withdrawal from Eastern Europe immediately after Hitler's invasion of Russia was an extremely difficult policy to implement. And, inevitably, the policy's problems were greatly multiplied when doubts were raised as to whether or not the industrial basis of German power would be weakened as had been agreed. It may well be true, as Walter Lippmann observed at the time, "that the best that was possible [was] an accommodation, a *modus vivendi*, a working arrangement, some simple form of cooperation, and that in demanding more than that we have been getting less than that, making the best the enemy of the good."⁴¹

Secretary Stimson seems to have shared this judgment and also to have recognized that the atomic bomb compounded the difficulties Truman's idealistic policy faced. By early September the Secretary of War had come full circle, concluding that "I was wrong" and that the attempt to use the atomic bomb to gain diplomatic objectives was "by far the more dangerous course."⁴² In a profoundly ironic, but unsuccessful, attempt to change the policy he had launched, shortly before leaving office Stimson urged an immediate and direct approach to Moscow to attempt to establish international control of atomic energy which might head off "an armament race of a rather desperate character." Apparently greatly disturbed by the bombing of Hiroshima, and now openly opposed to Secretary Byrnes, he advised: *"If we fail to approach them now and merely continue to negotiate with them, having this weapon rather ostentatiously on our hip, their suspicions and their distrust of our purposes and motives will increase."**

At the same time Stimson offered this advice, Secretary Byrnes attempted to explain to Molotov that the United States was "not interested in seeing anything but governments friendly to the Soviet

* Stimson's emphasis. The Secretary of War recorded one of his last attempts to convince the President of what he now believed to be a fundamental error in his own previous advice and in American policy: "I described the talk that I had had with Byrnes and told him what our differences were. I told him that both my plan

and Byrnes's plan contained chances which I outlined, and I said that I thought that in my method there was less danger than in his and also we would be on the right path towards world establishment of an international world, while on his plan we would be on the wrong path in that respect and (Continued on next page)

Union in adjacent countries." But the Soviet Foreign Minister was openly incredulous: "I must tell you I have doubts as to this, and it would not be honest to hide it."⁴³ Similarly, at this time former Soviet Foreign Minister Litvinov asked an American friend: "Why did you Americans wait till right now to begin opposing us in the Balkans and Eastern Europe? You should have done this three years ago. Now it is too late, and your complaints only arouse suspicions here."⁴⁴ And General Eisenhower, making a triumphal postwar visit to Moscow, sensed new and profound Soviet suspicions: "Before the atom bomb was used I would have said, yes, I was sure we could keep the peace with Russia. Now I don't know. . . . People are frightened and disturbed all over. Every one feels insecure again."⁴⁵

To recall the judgments of Stimson and Eisenhower in the autumn of 1945 is to state the ultimate question of to what extent the atomic bomb affected the entire structure of postwar American-Soviet relations. But it is not possible at this juncture to test Secretary Stimson's September view that "the problem of our satisfactory relations with Russia [was] not merely connected with but [was] virtually dominated by the problem of the atomic bomb."⁴⁶ Nor can the issue of why the atomic bomb was used be conclusively resolved.

This essay has attempted to describe the influence of the atomic bomb on certain questions of diplomacy. I do not believe that the reverse question—the influence of diplomacy upon the decision to use the atomic bomb—can be answered on the basis of the presently available evidence. However, it is possible to define the nature of the problem which new materials and further research may be able to solve.

A fruitful way to begin is to note General Eisenhower's recollection of the Potsdam discussion at which Stimson told him the weapon would be used against Japan:

During his recitation of the relevant facts, I had been conscious of a feeling of depression and so I voiced to him my grave misgivings,

(Continued from preceding page)
would be tending to revert to power politics." (Diary, Sept. 5, 1945.)

Stimson also reviewed the development of his thinking in a discussion with his succes-

sor, Robert P. Patterson: "I had a long talk with him. I told him how my view had been gradually formed; how in the beginning I was inclined to think we ought to hang on to the bomb . . . and its secrets; but

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first on the basis of my belief that Japan was already defeated and that dropping the bomb was completely unnecessary, and secondly because I thought that our country should avoid shocking world opinion by the use of a weapon whose employment was, I thought, no longer mandatory as a measure to save American lives. It was my belief that Japan was, at that very moment, seeking some way to surrender with a minimum loss of "face."

"It wasn't necessary to hit them with that awful thing," Eisenhower concluded.⁴⁷

Perhaps the most remarkable aspect of the decision to use the atomic bomb is that the President and his senior political advisers do not seem ever to have shared Eisenhower's "grave misgivings."* As we have seen, they simply assumed that they would use the bomb, never really giving serious consideration to not using it. Hence, to state in a precise way the question "Why was the atomic bomb used?" is to ask why senior political officials did *not* seriously question its use as Eisenhower did.

The first point to note is that the decision to use the weapon did not derive from overriding military considerations. Despite Truman's subsequent statement that the weapon "saved millions of lives,"⁴⁸ Eisenhower's judgment that it was "completely unnecessary" as a measure to save lives was almost certainly correct. This is not a matter of hindsight; *before the atomic bomb was dropped each of the Joint Chiefs of Staff advised that it was highly likely that Japan could be forced to surrender "unconditionally," without use of the bomb and without an invasion.* Indeed, this characterization of the position taken by the senior military advisers is a conservative one.

General Marshall's June 18 appraisal was the most cautiously phrased advice offered by any of the Joint Chiefs: "The impact of

that gradually I had found that I was wrong and that that would be by far the more dangerous course than to make an effort with Russia particularly to get on terms with us of confidence in which we would eliminate the manufacture of such bombs for war purposes—eliminate the development of the atomic energy of the explosive kind, and confine ourselves to its use and the development of its more controllable smaller powers for commerce . . ." (Diary, Sept. 17, 1945.)

Stimson left office at the end of September deeply disturbed at having failed to change the direction of the strategy he had launched. (Diary, Sept. 21, 1945.) For a memorandum in which he offered his final detailed views to the President, see Appendix III.

* But see: "I must say that personally I am not at all sure that we were well advised to use it." (Atomic Energy Commission, *Oppenheimer Hearings*, p. 367.)

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Russian entry on the already hopeless Japanese may well be the decisive action levering them into capitulation . . .”⁴⁹ Admiral Leahy was absolutely certain there was no need for the bombing to obviate the necessity of an invasion.⁵⁰ His judgment after the fact was the same as his view before the bombing: “It is my opinion that the use of this barbarous weapon at Hiroshima and Nagasaki was of no material assistance in our war against Japan. The Japanese were already defeated and ready to surrender . . .”⁵¹ Similarly, through most of 1945 Admiral King believed the bomb unnecessary,⁵² and Generals Arnold and LeMay defined the official Air Force position in this way: Whether or not the atomic bomb should be dropped was not for the Air Force to decide, but explosion of the bomb was not necessary to win the war or make an invasion unnecessary.*⁵³

Similar views prevailed in Britain long before the bombs were used. General Ismay recalls that by the time of Potsdam, “for some time past it had been firmly fixed in my mind that the Japanese were tottering.”⁵⁴ Ismay’s reaction to the suggestion of the bombing was, like Eisenhower’s and Leahy’s, one of “revulsion.”⁵⁵ And Churchill, who as early as September 1944, felt that Russian entry was likely to force capitulation,⁵⁶ has written: “It would be a mistake to suppose that the fate of Japan was settled by the atomic bomb. Her defeat was certain before the first bomb fell . . .”⁵⁷

The military appraisals made before the weapons were used have been confirmed by numerous postsurrender studies. The best known is that of the United States Strategic Bombing Survey. The Survey’s conclusion is unequivocal: “Japan would have surrendered even if the atomic bombs had not been dropped, even if Russia had not entered the war, and even if no invasion had been planned or contemplated.”†⁵⁸

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*At the time he argued against the use of the atomic bomb, Eisenhower advised the additional point that the war could easily be ended before Soviet entry. (Eisenhower, *Crusade in Europe*, pp. 441-42.)

† See also Marshall’s postwar statement that the atomic bombs precipitated the surrender only “by months”; Bush’s view that “the war would have ended before long in any case, for Japan had been brought nearly to her knees”; Curtis LeMay’s opinion that the war would have ended in two

weeks (“the atomic bomb had nothing to do with the end of the war”); Claire Chennault’s view that the Russian declaration of war was the decisive factor; and the arguments of Morton, Baldwin, Blackett, and Craven and Cate, that the atomic bomb was not needed to force a surrender before an invasion. (J. P. Sutherland, “The Story General Marshall Told Me,” *U.S. News & World Report*, Nov. 2, 1959, p. 52; Bush, V., *Modern Arms and Free Men*, p. 101; *New York Herald Tribune*, Sept. 21, 1945; *New York Times*, Aug. 15, 1945;

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That military considerations were not decisive is confirmed—and illuminated—by the fact that the President did not even ask the opinion of the military adviser most directly concerned. General MacArthur, Supreme Commander of Allied Forces in the Pacific, was simply informed of the weapon shortly before it was used at Hiroshima.⁵⁹ Before his death he stated on numerous occasions that, like Eisenhower, he believed the atomic bomb was completely unnecessary from a military point of view.⁶⁰

Although military considerations were not primary, as we have seen, unquestionably political considerations related to Russia played a major role in the decision; from at least mid-May American policy makers hoped to end the hostilities before the Red Army entered Manchuria. For this reason they had no wish to test whether Russian entry into the war would force capitulation—as most thought likely—long before the scheduled November invasion. Indeed, they actively attempted to delay Stalin's declaration of war.

Nevertheless, it would be wrong to conclude that the atomic bomb was used simply to keep the Red Army out of Manchuria. Given the desperate efforts of the Japanese to surrender, and Truman's willingness to offer assurances to the Emperor, it is entirely possible that the war could have been ended by negotiation before the Red Army had begun its attack. But, again, as we have seen, after Alamogordo neither the President nor his senior advisers were interested in exploring this possibility.

One reason may have been their fear that if time-consuming negotiations were once initiated, the Red Army might attack in order to seize Manchurian objectives. But, if this explanation is accepted, once more one must conclude that the bomb was used primarily because it was felt to be politically important to prevent Soviet domination of the area.

Such a conclusion is very difficult to accept, for American interests in Manchuria, although historically important to the State Department, were not of great significance. The further question therefore arises: Were there other political reasons for using the atomic bomb? In approaching this question, it is important to note that most of the men

Morton, "The Decision to Use the Atomic Bomb," *Command Decisions*, ed. K. R. Greenfield, p. 408; *Military and Political Consequences of Atomic Energy*, pp. 116-

30; Baldwin, *Great Mistakes of the War*, p. 84; Craven and Cate, *Air Forces in World War II*, Vol. V, p. 726.)

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involved at the time who since have made their views public always mention *two* considerations which dominated discussions. The first was the desire to end the Japanese war quickly, which, as we have seen, was not primarily a military consideration, but a political one. The second is always referred to indirectly.

In June, for example, a leading member of the Interim Committee's scientific panel, A. H. Compton, advised against the Franck report's suggestion of a technical demonstration of the new weapon: Not only was there a possibility that this might not end the war promptly, but failure to make a combat demonstration would mean the 'loss of the opportunity to impress the world with the national sacrifices that enduring security demanded.'* The general phrasing that the bomb was needed 'to impress the world' has been made more specific by J. Robert Oppenheimer. Testifying on this matter some years later he stated that the second of the two "overriding considerations" in discussions regarding the bomb was "the effect of our actions on the stability, on our strength, and the stability of the postwar world."⁶¹ And the problem of postwar stability was inevitably the problem of Russia. Oppenheimer has put it this way: "Much of the discussion revolved around the question raised by Secretary Stimson as to whether there was any hope at all of using this development to get less barbarous relations with the Russians."⁶²

Vannevar Bush, Stimson's chief aide for atomic matters, has been quite explicit: "That bomb was developed on time . . ." Not only did it mean a quick end to the Japanese war, but "it was also delivered on time so that there was no necessity for any concessions to Russia at the end of the war."⁶³

In essence, the second of the two overriding considerations seems to have been that a combat demonstration was needed to convince the Russians to accept the American plan for a stable peace. And the crucial point of this effort was the need to force agreement on the main questions in dispute: the American proposals for Central and Eastern Europe. President Truman may well have expressed the key consideration in October 1945; publicly urging the necessity of a more conventional form of military power (his proposal for universal military

* The words set off are a quotation of the paraphrase provided by the historians of the

U.S. Atomic Energy Commission. (Hewlett and Anderson, *The New World*, p. 367.)

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training), in a personal appearance before Congress the President declared: "It is only by strength that we can impress the fact upon possible future aggressors that we will tolerate no threat to peace . . ." ⁸⁴

If indeed the "second consideration" involved in the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki was the desire to impress the Russians, it might explain the strangely ambiguous statement by Truman that not only did the bomb end the war, but it gave the world "a chance to face the facts." ⁸⁵ It would also accord with Stimson's private advice to McCloy: "We have got to regain the lead and perhaps do it in a pretty rough and realistic way. . . . We have coming into action a weapon which will be unique. Now the thing [to do is] . . . let our actions speak for themselves." ⁸⁶ Again, it would accord with Stimson's statement to Truman that the "greatest complication" would occur if the President negotiated with Stalin before the bomb had been "laid on Japan." ⁸⁷ It would tie in with the fact that from mid-May strategy toward all major diplomatic problems was based upon the assumption the bomb would be demonstrated. Finally, it might explain why none of the highest civilian officials seriously questioned the use of the bomb as Eisenhower did; for, having reversed the basic direction of diplomatic strategy *because* of the atomic bomb, it would have been very difficult indeed for anyone subsequently to challenge an idea which had come to dominate all calculations of high policy.*

At present no final conclusion can be reached on this question. But the problem can be defined with some precision: Why did the American government refuse to attempt to exploit Japanese efforts to surrender? Or, alternatively, why did they refuse to test whether a Russian declaration of war would force capitulation? Were Hiroshima and Nagasaki bombed primarily to impress the world with the need to

* It might also explain why the sober and self-controlled Stimson reacted so strongly when Eisenhower objected to the bombing: "The Secretary was deeply perturbed by my attitude, almost angrily refuting the reasons I gave . . ." (Eisenhower, *Mandate for Change*, p. 313.) Stimson's post-Hiroshima reversal, and his repeated references to the gravity of the moral issues raised by the new weapon, are evidence of his own doubts. Eisenhower's searching criticism may well have touched upon a very tender point, namely, Stimson's undoubted awareness that Hiroshima and Nagasaki

were to be sacrificed primarily for political, not military, reasons.

See also Williams, *The Tragedy of American Diplomacy*, p. 254, and Fleming, *The Cold War*, I, pp. 296-302. Compare Irving's account of the bombing of Dresden. See especially his discussion of the precisely parallel argument that Churchill felt it politically important to impress Stalin with overwhelming air power when Central and Eastern European issues were discussed at Yalta. (*The Destruction of Dresden*, pp. 86-102.)

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accept America's plan for a stable and lasting peace—that is, primarily, America's plan for Europe? The evidence strongly suggests that the view which the President's personal representative offered to one of the atomic scientists in May 1945 was an accurate statement of policy: "Mr. Byrnes did not argue that it was necessary to use the bomb against the cities of Japan in order to win the war . . . Mr. Byrnes's . . . view [was] that our possessing and demonstrating the bomb would make Russia more manageable in Europe. . . ." ⁶⁸